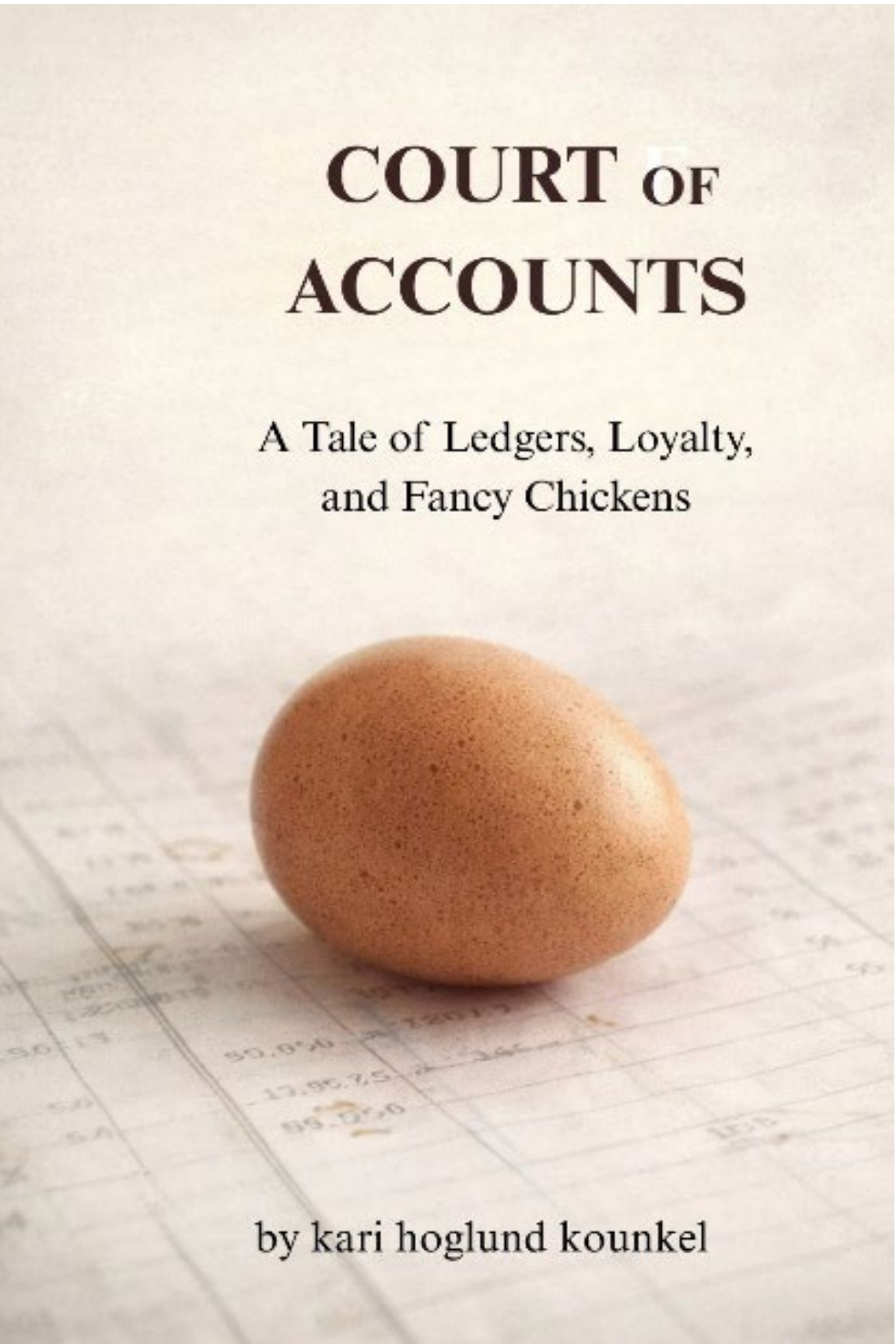
COURT OF ACCOUNTS

A Tale of Ledgers, Loyalty, and Fancy Chickens



by kari hoglund kounkel

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Concept Summary

Once upon a balance sheet, there was a kingdom called Eggerton that sold eggs and counted them carefully.

This story follows Lady Delia Hearthstone, Operations Steward of Eggerton, and the Court of Accounts—a curious band of scribes, gatekeepers, cartographers, and truth-tellers who run the realm by a radical idea: don't chase chickens; count eggs.

When a slick rival rolls into the market with shiny promises and suspiciously low prices, the kingdom does not panic or posture. Instead, they reach for their tools:

Cash flow.

Budgets.

Receivables.

Creativity.

Chicken poop.

(Yes, really.)

This is a business parable disguised as a whimsical saga.

There are omelets. There are spreadsheets. There are chickens in questionable outfits.

And somewhere along the way, you realize this is not really about eggs at all.

The Court of Accounts

A kingdom that doesn't chase chickens. It counts eggs. And sometimes dresses them.

THE ROYAL COURT (The Big Truth-Holders)

Lady Delia Hearthstone — Operations Steward

The protagonist. Cheerfully lethal. Appears whimsical. Thinks in systems. Knows exactly what's happening and exactly when to act. Her weapon is clarity disguised as charm.

Queen Verity of the Ledgers — The Balance Sheet

Calm. Unmovable. Never impressed. She holds the entire truth at once and does not blink.

The King — Ownership / Executive Authority

Listens more than he speaks. Trusts the court. Understands that power comes from knowing when not to interfere.

Sir Ludo Quarterly — Profit & Loss

A bit theatrical. Loves performance metrics. Knows whether the kingdom is winning this period, not in theory.

Lady Continuance — Statement of Equity

Long memory. Legacy thinker. Remembers every season the kingdom survived and why it still stands.

THE RECORD KEEPERS (The Truth Anchors)

Pip the Daily Scribe — The Journal

Observant. Unassuming. Dangerous in his accuracy. If Pip writes it down, it becomes real.

Magnus Vaultwell — General Ledger

Quiet. Meticulous. Sees patterns others miss. Nothing escapes him. Nothing.

Elowen Mapwright — Chart of Accounts

The cartographer of money. If you don't know where something belongs, she does.

Theo the Tally — Trial Balance

Shy. Brilliant. Accidentally creative. Catches lies before they become disasters.

THE MONEY MOVERS (Where Reality Hits)

Garrick at the Gate — Cash Flow

Tracks the pulse of the kingdom. Knows that profit without cash is a fairy tale.

Callum the Relentless — Accounts Receivable

Polite. Persistent. Impossible to ignore. Understands the difference between patience and avoidance.

Beatrice the Patient — Accounts Payable

Strategic calm. Pays with intention. Knows timing is power.

Rowan the Truth Teller — Bank Reconciliation

Has zero tolerance for "close enough." The moment something doesn't match, Rowan notices.

THE ANALYSTS & ADVISORS (The Interpreters)

The Oracles (Three) — Financial Ratios

Cold-eyed. Mathematical. Annoyingly correct. They tell you how outsiders will judge you—whether you like it or not.

The Prophet — Cash Flow Forecast

Sees six weeks ahead when others see tomorrow. Never dramatic. Always right.

The Collections Enforcer — Aging Reports

Keeps score of who's behaving and who's drifting. A quiet warning system.

THE INVENTORY CREW (The Physical Truth)

The Warehouse Master — Inventory

Knows exactly what's on the shelves and what's rotting quietly.

The Sacrifice Counter — Cost of Goods Sold

Understands what it truly costs to make a thing exist. Nothing is free. Especially not eggs.

COMMUNICATION & OPERATIONS

The Herald of Honest Eggs — Marketing

Not hype. Not spin. Tells the truth loudly enough that people feel it in their bones.

The Clapper Boy — Internal Communications / Ops Signal

Fast. Trusted. Never confused about urgency. When the clapper sounds, the court assembles.

THE ALLIES

The Trading Partners — Vendors & Suppliers

They remember who pays fairly.

The Loyal Subjects — Customers

They vote with their feet and their purses.

The Shield Bearers — Insurance

Boring until they're not.

The Allied Crowns — Investors & Partners

Helpful when aligned. Dangerous when ignored.

The Elder Council — Mentors

They've seen this movie before.

The Mercenaries — Contractors

Useful. Skilled. Temporary by design.

THE RIVAL KINGDOM

Prince Michlen the Misled of Crestfall

Young. Flashy. Price-driven. Mistakes movement for progress.

Silas the Ledgerkeeper — Crestfall's General Ledger

Keeper of records Michlen won't read. Future defector. Undone by chicken fashion.

THE THREATS

The Moneylender Lord — Debt

Neutral. Patient. Always watching ratios.

The Deserters — Bad Debt

What happens when promises evaporate.

The Watchers — Regulators

They do not care about your story.

The Long Winter — Economic Downturn

Inevitable. Survivable—if prepared.

Prologue

The View from Crestfall

The old king died on a Tuesday, which felt appropriately unremarkable for a man who had spent forty years on a throne and never quite filled it.

Prince Michlen stood at his father's bedside as the final breath rattled out, and felt... nothing. No grief. No relief. Just a hollow space where something should have been, like reaching into a coin purse and finding it empty.

His father had ruled Crestfall with the particular mediocrity of a man who knew his limitations and resented them. The kingdom survived under his reign—never thrived, never collapsed, just... continued. Crops grew adequately. Taxes were collected without incident. The people neither celebrated their king nor cursed him. They simply endured him, the way one endures a persistent drizzle.

But there was one thing that had consumed the old king, one obsession that had sharpened over the decades until it became the only thing that animated

his otherwise listless eyes: Eggerton. Their eggs. Their ridiculous, infuriating prosperity.

"They have fat chickens," his father used to mutter, staring east from the castle windows. "Arrogant roosters. Eggs with shells so thick you could build walls with them. And their people—" his voice would turn bitter here, curdling like milk left too long in the sun, "—their people are happy. Can you imagine? Happy."

Young Michlen had grown up on these complaints like other children grew up on bedtime stories. Eggerton's bounty. Their inexplicable joy. The way their market stalls overflowed while Crestfall's merely... sufficed.

"It should be ours," his father would say. "All of it. They don't deserve what they have."

But the old king never did anything about it. He watched and he envied and he muttered, and then he died on a Tuesday with that envy still lodged in his throat like a bone he couldn't swallow.

Michlen believed it had killed him. Not the age, not the illness that had wasted his frame over the final months. The envy. Decades of wanting what he couldn't have, watching what he couldn't match, until

the wanting itself became a poison that ate him from within.

Standing over the body, Michlen made a vow. He would not die like this. He would not spend his reign staring east and wishing. He would take what his father had only coveted.

He would make Crestfall great by making the neighbors small.

* * *

The coronation was swift and sparsely attended. Crestfall's nobles came because protocol demanded it, not because hope drew them. They had watched Michlen grow from a sullen child into a restless young man, all sharp edges and simmering impatience. They did not expect greatness. They hoped merely for competence.

Silas the Ledgerkeeper [CRESTFALL'S GENERAL LEDGER] stood at the back of the throne room, clutching a leather satchel filled with documents the new king would never read. He had served the old king faithfully, maintaining records that told Crestfall's true story in numbers rather than narrative. The ledgers showed a kingdom that was stable, if

unspectacular. Adequate harvests. Manageable debts. Room for careful growth if anyone had the patience to pursue it.

But patience required trust, and trust required listening, and Michlen had never been good at either.

After the crown was placed and the oaths were sworn, Silas requested an audience. He wanted to show the new king the state of the treasury, the opportunities hidden in the margins, the slow but certain path to prosperity that required only discipline and time.

Michlen waved him away without looking at the documents.

"I don't need numbers," the new king said. "I need results. My father spent forty years studying ledgers and died with nothing to show for it. I won't make the same mistake."

"Your Majesty," Silas said carefully, "the ledgers don't merely record the past. They illuminate the future. If you would only—"

"The future is what I make it." Michlen's eyes were bright with something that might have been vision or might have been fever. "Eggerton didn't become prosperous by reading documents. They became

prosperous by acting. By doing. By taking their place in the market and holding it."

"With respect, Your Majesty, I believe they became prosperous by understanding their costs, managing their resources, and building trust over generations—"

"Trust." Michlen laughed, a short, sharp sound. "My father trusted time. He trusted patience. He trusted that if he simply maintained what he had, somehow more would come. And what did it get him?"

Silas had no answer. Or rather, he had an answer—it got him a stable kingdom and a peaceful death—but he knew the new king wouldn't hear it.

"I want a plan," Michlen continued. "Not for next year. Not for next decade. For now. How do we expand into their market? How do we take what they have?"

"Your Majesty, aggressive expansion without proper financial foundation—"

"Find a way." Michlen turned away, already done with the conversation. "Or I'll find someone who will."

Silas clutched his satchel and bowed. The documents inside—the careful projections, the historical trends, the warnings written in ink and arithmetic—would

remain unread. The new king wanted action, not information. Speed, not wisdom.

As he retreated from the throne room, Silas passed a window that faced east. In the distance, beyond the hills, lay the kingdom Michlen so envied. Silas had visited their market once, years ago, on business for the old king. He remembered the fat chickens. The arrogant roosters. The eggs with shells so thick they gleamed like polished stone.

But mostly he remembered the people. The way they laughed with each other, vendor and customer alike. The way the merchants knew their neighbors' names and children. The way the whole market hummed with something that Crestfall's markets never quite achieved.

He hadn't known what to call it then. Now, watching his new king pace with hungry eyes, he thought he understood.

They had joy. And joy, Silas suspected, could not be conquered. Only grown.

But Michlen would try to conquer it anyway. And Silas would watch, and record, and wait for the collapse that the ledgers already foretold.

* * *

Within a fortnight, the plans were drawn. Within a month, the wagons were commissioned—crimson paint, gold lettering, a shine that announced ambition if not substance. Within a season, Crestfall eggs would appear in Eggerton's market, priced to undercut, designed to disrupt.

"We'll drive them out," Michlen declared to his council, most of whom had learned quickly that disagreement was unwelcome. "Lower prices. Flashier presentation. We'll take their customers before they know what's happening."

"And the cost?" asked Lord Pemberton, one of the few nobles old enough and wealthy enough to risk a question. "Selling below our expenses will drain the treasury."

"Short-term sacrifice for long-term gain," Michlen said with the confidence of someone who had never actually read a ledger. "Once we control the market, we raise prices. Simple."

Silas, standing in his usual corner, said nothing. He had already tried. The numbers were clear: this strategy would bleed Crestfall dry long before it damaged Eggerton. But numbers required someone

willing to read them, and Michlen had made his position on reading abundantly clear.

"What about our own people?" asked Lady Ashworth, whose lands bordered the eastern hills. "If we're sending our best eggs to their market at a loss, what remains for Crestfall's tables?"

"Sacrifice," Michlen said, as if the word were a virtue rather than a wound. "Our people will understand. They want Crestfall to be great."

Lady Ashworth did not point out that Crestfall's people mostly wanted to eat. She had learned, as they all had, that Michlen heard only what confirmed his existing beliefs. Everything else was noise to be dismissed.

The meeting adjourned. The plans proceeded. And in his small office overlooking the courtyard, Silas the Ledgerkeeper opened a fresh journal and began to document the disaster in progress.

Somewhere to the east, in Eggerton—a kingdom that had no idea what was coming—a woman named Lady De was probably walking her market, an egg in her pocket, counting blessings she didn't yet know were threatened.

Silas hoped she was paying attention. Someone would need to be.

Chapter 1

The Weighty Egg

Morning light spilled across the counting hall like honey poured from a lazy jar, pooling in the corners where dust motes performed their slow, sacred ballet.

The Court of Accounts had already begun its work.

Queen Verity of the Ledgers [THE BALANCE SHEET] sat at the head of the long oak table, her presence as steady as the balance sheet she embodied. She did not speak often in these morning gatherings—she did not need to. Her role was to hold the whole picture: what the kingdom owned, what it owed, and what remained when the two were reconciled. The others reported to her not because she demanded it, but because accuracy flowed naturally toward her the way rivers find the sea.

Pip the Daily Scribe [THE JOURNAL] read aloud the happenings of yesterday—sales steady, trades honest, the rhythm of commerce ticking along like a heart that knows its job and does it without complaint. His quill scratched against parchment with the satisfying sound of truth being pinned down before it could wriggle away.

Garrick at the Gate [CASH FLOW STATEMENT] frowned thoughtfully at the coin trays, his fingers moving across copper and silver the way a musician's hands remember strings. As keeper of cash flow, he tracked every coin that entered and exited the kingdom's coffers—not because he was suspicious, but because cash was the blood of the realm, and you could not afford to guess about blood.

"Cash is moving," he said, "but slower in the afternoons. Like the river when it hits that wide bend past Miller's Creek—still flowing, just taking its time about it."

Elowen Mapwright [CHART OF ACCOUNTS] smoothed her budget maps with palms that had memorized every ridge and valley of projected income. As the kingdom's Cartographer, she charted where money should flow before it ever arrived—the prophecy of prudent spending. The parchment crinkled beneath her touch like dry leaves underfoot, each line a path the kingdom might walk in the week ahead.

"The week ahead looks balanced," she said. "No surprises penciled in."

Magnus Vaultwell [THE GENERAL LEDGER], Master Archivist, sat in his usual corner surrounded by towers of bound records. Every transaction Pip captured in

his daily journal eventually found its way to Magnus, who organized them into the great ledger that told the kingdom's complete financial story. He looked up briefly, spectacles catching the light, then returned to cross-referencing yesterday's entries with their proper accounts.

Callum the Relentless [ACCOUNTS RECEIVABLE] reviewed his collection routes, a map of the kingdom's outstanding debts spread before him. Every promise to pay passed through his hands eventually. Some came willingly. Some needed reminding. All came eventually—Callum made certain of that.

Beatrice the Patient [ACCOUNTS PAYABLE] sorted invoices by due date with the calm precision of someone who understood that patience was not passivity but strategy. As keeper of accounts payable, she orchestrated when the kingdom paid its own obligations—never too early (why give up coin before necessary?), never too late (why damage trust for a few days' float?).

And at the center of it all stood Lady Delia Hearthstone [OPERATIONS STEWARD/BOOKKEEPER]—called "Lady De" by those who trusted her—Operations Steward of Eggerton,

one perfect brown egg balanced in her palm like a small, fragile planet.

She was smiling.

This was the rhythm she loved—the quiet truth of work well done. Not the flash of a brilliant scheme or the thunder of a crisis averted, but this: the steady accumulation of small accuracies, the daily discipline of knowing exactly where you stood. Some people found counting tedious. Lady De found it holy. Every number told a story. Every balanced ledger was a prayer answered.

The King [EXECUTIVE AUTHORITY/OWNERSHIP] entered quietly, as was his way. He did not interrupt the morning reports, did not demand attention or precedence. He simply took his seat beside Queen Verity and listened. This was his gift—and the kingdom's great fortune. A ruler who trusted his court. A leader who understood that wisdom often lived in the people closest to the work.

As the court dispersed to their posts, Lady De slipped the egg into her apron pocket and headed for the door.

"Market rounds?" Pip asked without looking up from his journal.

"Market rounds," she confirmed.

It was a practice she'd kept since her earliest days as Steward—this insistence on walking the territory herself. Other leaders trusted reports. Lady De trusted reports too, but she also trusted her own eyes, her own ears, the particular hum of a market that was thriving versus one that was merely surviving. You could read a ledger and know the numbers. You had to walk the stalls to know the story behind them.

Besides, she thought as she stepped into the morning sun, you can't count what you don't touch. You can't trust what you don't see.

The egg in her pocket was warm against her hip. She never walked the market without one—a small ritual, perhaps silly to anyone watching, but essential to her. The egg was the point of everything. The coops, the feed, the workers, the sales, the ledgers, the court itself—all of it existed to bring eggs from hen to hand to table. When the numbers got abstract, when the reports piled high and the concerns grew theoretical, Lady De would reach into her pocket and feel that smooth, fragile weight. This. This is what we're doing. This is what we're protecting.

She was in it to win it. But winning meant staying close to what mattered.

* * *

The market square bustled with its usual morning energy—merchants calling out prices, children darting between stalls, the smell of bread and smoke and animal and earth all tangled together into something that smelled like commerce. Lady De moved through it with the ease of long familiarity, nodding to vendors she'd known for years, pausing to examine a competitor's display of preserves (good quality, fair price, no threat), stopping to chat with Old Maren who sold wool and always knew which way the economic winds were blowing.

"Busy morning?" Lady De asked.

"Busy enough," Maren said, her fingers never stopping their work at the spinning wheel. "Though there's something new down by the east corner. Flashy wagon. Eggs, if you can believe it. Bold of them."

Lady De kept her expression neutral. "Oh?"

"Red paint. Gold letters. Prices that made me blink twice." Maren shrugged. "Might be nothing. Might be something. You'd know better than me."

Lady De thanked her and moved on, but her pace had shifted—still unhurried, still casual, but with a new

direction. East corner. She wove through the crowd, past the spice merchant and the candle maker and the stall that sold leather goods of questionable origin, until she saw it.

The wagon gleamed like a fresh wound.

Crimson paint, so new it practically sparkled. Gold lettering that caught the morning light: CRESTFALL FARMS — FINEST EGGS IN THE REALM. The prices chalked on the board beside it were indeed low—not ruinously so, but enough to make a careful shopper pause and calculate.

A young man in a clean apron stood beside the wagon, calling out to passersby with the polished enthusiasm of someone who'd rehearsed his pitch. Behind him, crates of eggs were stacked with almost theatrical precision.

Lady De watched from a distance, one hand in her apron pocket, fingers resting against the warm curve of her own egg. She noted the quality of the wagon (expensive). The uniformity of the eggs on display (suspiciously perfect). The way the young man's smile never quite reached his eyes (performing, not connecting). The small cluster of customers who'd gathered—curious, but not yet convinced.

She didn't approach. Didn't need to. The ledgers would tell her soon enough if this was a problem. But ledgers were lagging indicators. They told you what had already happened. Eyes told you what was about to.

Crestfall. Eggerton. She'd heard rumors that the old king had passed and his son had taken the throne—young, ambitious, eager to prove himself. This wagon, with its shine and its swagger, had that energy. The energy of someone trying to buy what they hadn't yet earned.

Lady De committed the details to memory, then turned and walked back through the market at her usual pace. No rush. No alarm. Just information, gathered and stored, waiting to become useful.

The egg in her pocket was still warm.

* * *

Back in the counting hall, the King and Queen Verity had settled into their morning review. Lady De approached them with the calm of someone delivering weather observations, not warnings.

"All is well," she said easily, drawing the egg from her pocket and letting it rest in her palm. "Though I did

notice something in the market this morning. A wagon. Red paint, gold lettering. Crestfall."

The King's eyebrow rose slightly. Queen Verity's expression did not change, but her quill paused over her parchment.

"Eggerton," the King said slowly. "Young Prince Michlen [DIRECT COMPETITOR] took the throne last season. Michlen the Misled, some of the diplomatic couriers are calling him—though perhaps that's unkind. He inherited a proud kingdom."

"Proud, and hungry," Queen Verity added, her voice quiet but precise. "The old king watched us for forty years and never made a move. If the son is different—if he's impatient—he may try to take what his father only coveted."

Lady De turned the egg over, watching light slide across its shell. "Maybe he simply wants to expand his reach. Competition isn't always a threat."

"Maybe," Queen Verity said. "Or maybe he's spending faster than his ledgers can track. Expansion without foundation is just expensive falling."

"Probably nothing," she said. "Still—worth watching."

* * *

That evening, after the counting hall had emptied and the candles burned low, Lady De found herself lingering over Elowen's budget maps.

The kingdom was healthy. But healthy was not the same as growing.

She traced her finger along the projected income lines, the careful estimates of egg sales and market revenue. Steady. Reliable. And utterly insufficient if they wanted to expand the coops, hire more workers, reach new markets.

"You're still here."

Lady De looked up to find the Prophet [CASH FLOW FORECAST] standing in the doorway. Unlike the other members of the court, the Prophet dealt not in what had happened or what was happening, but in what might come. Cash flow forecasting was her domain—the art of predicting tomorrow's treasury based on today's patterns.

"Thinking about growth," Lady De admitted.

The Prophet crossed to the table, her robes whispering against the stone floor. She studied the maps with the particular intensity of someone who saw numbers as living things.

"Growth requires capital," she said. "Capital we could generate—slowly—or borrow."

"The Moneylender Lord."

"He would want to see our ratios. The Oracles [FINANCIAL RATIOS] would need to prepare a full analysis. Queen Verity would need to present the balance sheet." The Prophet paused. "It could be done. The question is whether it should be."

Lady De set the egg down gently on the table, where it sat like a small moon in the lamplight.

"Not yet," she said. "But soon, maybe. Let's see what Crestfall brings first."

Don't chase the chickens, she reminded herself. Count the eggs.

Chapter 2

The Numbers Whisper

One week later, the signs appeared.

Not loudly. The kingdom did not wake to trumpet blasts or proclamations nailed to doors. The shift came the way weather changes when you're not looking—one moment the sky clear, the next a smudge of gray on the horizon that might be nothing, might be everything.

The morning court gathered as always, but the energy had shifted. Pip's quill moved faster. Garrick's frown had deepened. Even Magnus Vaultwell looked up from his ledgers more frequently than usual, as if the numbers were whispering things he didn't quite like.

Callum the Relentless walked the streets that week with his satchel lighter than usual. He returned each evening not with coin, but with promises.

"They'll pay Friday," he reported, standing before the court with the particular weariness of a man who had heard Friday from sixteen different lips. "Or next week. Or when the wool sells."

The promises were good. The people were honest. But promises did not fill the vault.

"Receivables are stretching," Lady De said, studying the aging report Callum had prepared. The Collections Enforcer [AGING REPORTS] had helped him compile it—a detailed accounting of who owed what, and for how long. Accounts once paid within ten days now lingered at fifteen. Twenty. A few crept toward thirty, like children staying up past bedtime, testing boundaries.

"Not alarming yet," she continued. "But the pattern is new."

Beatrice the Patient had noticed it too. She spent her days in quieter negotiations now—not with customers, but with suppliers.

"I've asked for extended terms on the grain delivery," she told the court. "And the hay merchant agreed to split our payment across two weeks instead of one."

"You're borrowing time," Magnus Vaultwell observed from behind his fortress of ledgers.

"I'm spacing it carefully," Beatrice corrected, her voice soft but certain. "We can meet every obligation. We simply need to orchestrate when."

This was her gift—the understanding that cash flow was not a river but a series of locks and dams, each one requiring careful timing. Pay too fast and you drain the reservoir. Pay too slow and trust erodes like riverbanks in a flood. But find the rhythm, honor the sequence, and water reached everywhere it needed to go.

Rowan the Truth Teller [BANK RECONCILIATION] arrived midmorning with the bank reconciliation—that sacred document that compared what the kingdom believed it had with what the bank confirmed it held. Every coin accounted for. Every discrepancy investigated. Today, the numbers matched perfectly, which was both reassuring and insufficient.

"The balance is accurate," Rowan announced. "But accuracy doesn't tell us why the inflow has slowed."

Queen Verity spoke for the first time that morning. Her voice carried the weight of the balance sheet she represented—every asset, every liability, every thread of equity woven into the kingdom's financial fabric.

"Show me the pattern," she said.

Magnus produced a summary from his general ledger: month-over-month comparisons, account-by-account

analysis. The story emerged slowly, like a figure stepping out of fog.

Sales had softened—not collapsed, but eased. The market stalls that once sold out by noon now carried inventory into the afternoon. And the margins on bulk orders had thinned, as if someone were undercutting prices just enough to make customers hesitate.

"Crestfall," the King said quietly.

Lady De nodded. The red wagon had become a fixture in the market square. Prince Michlen's representatives arrived earlier each morning, their eggs priced just below the kingdom's—not dramatically, but consistently. Enough to plant doubt. Enough to make loyal customers wonder if loyalty was worth the premium.

"They're buying market share," Sir Ludo Quarterly [PROFIT & LOSS STATEMENT] observed. He dealt in the kingdom's profit and loss—the performance of the realm over time. "Selling cheap, absorbing losses. It's a gamble. They're betting they can outlast us."

"Can they?" the King asked.

Sir Ludo shrugged—a surprisingly casual gesture from the court's performance keeper. "Depends on their reserves. On their tolerance for pain. On whether

Michlen has advisors who will tell him the truth, or flatterers who will tell him what he wants to hear."

The court fell silent. Everyone knew what Sir Ludo was really saying: the difference between the two kingdoms might come down to the quality of counsel each ruler received. And whether they listened.

Throughout it all, Pip the Daily Scribe wrote furiously. His journal entries had grown longer, more detailed, capturing not just transactions but textures—the hesitation in a merchant's voice, the way certain customers now walked past the kingdom's stall without stopping, the exact shade of red on that rival wagon (crimson, he noted, with a shine that suggested recent painting, which suggested investment, which suggested this was not a passing fancy).

Pip understood something the others sometimes forgot: the books were not merely records. They were witnesses. And witnesses needed to capture everything, because you never knew which detail would matter until the moment it did.

* * *

That evening, Delia convened a smaller council: herself, Lady De, Elowen Mapwright, the Prophet, and Theo the Tally.

Theo the Tally [TRIAL BALANCE]'s role was often overlooked—he prepared the trial balance, that preliminary check that ensured all debits equaled all credits before the formal statements were prepared. It was unglamorous work, the accounting equivalent of making sure your shoes were tied before running a race. But Theo caught errors before they compounded. He was the kingdom's last line of defense against self-deception.

"I want options," Lady De said. "Not panic. Options."

The Prophet spread her forecasting scrolls across the table. "At current trajectory, we maintain stability for six months. Longer if Beatrice can continue extending payables without damaging supplier relationships. But stability isn't growth."

"What would growth require?"

"Capital investment. New coops. More hens. Expanded distribution." The Prophet traced the lines of projected cash flow. "We could pursue organic growth—slow, funded by retained earnings. Or accelerated growth—funded by debt."

"The Moneylender Lord," Elowen said.

"He would require a full presentation," the Prophet continued. "Queen Verity's balance sheet. Sir Ludo's profit statements. My forecasts. And—" she paused significantly, "—the Oracles' ratio analysis."

Lady De leaned back. The Oracles. She almost never consulted them—not because their work wasn't valuable, but because the kingdom's operations had been steady enough that deep ratio analysis felt like overkill. Current ratio, quick ratio, debt-to-equity, profit margins... numbers that mattered enormously when someone outside was evaluating you, but that daily operations rarely demanded.

"If we approach the Moneylender Lord," she said slowly, "we'll need to know our own numbers better than he does. We'll need to see ourselves the way a lender sees us."

"Is that a bad thing?" Theo asked.

Lady De smiled slightly. "No. It might be exactly what we need. Even if we never take the loan—knowing what we'd look like if we asked might teach us something."

She picked up the egg from her desk—still there, still patient, still waiting.

"All right," she said. "We watch a bit longer. But let's ask the Oracles to prepare their analysis. Let's know our ratios before anyone else asks to see them. And let's see what Crestfall does next."

When Delia read Pip's journal that night, lamp flame flickering across pages dense with observation, she did not pace. Did not summon emergency councils or draft defensive proclamations.

She simply nodded.

"Now we watch."

Chapter 3

Counting Eggs, Counting Moves

The court did not rush.

This was perhaps the hardest discipline—harder than early mornings, harder than difficult conversations, harder than the math itself. The discipline of not reacting when every instinct screamed to do something, anything, to prove you were not simply standing still while the world shifted beneath your feet.

But Lady De had learned something in her years as Steward, something she tried to teach every member of her court: the difference between stillness and paralysis. A frozen person cannot move. A still person has chosen not to—yet. They are gathering. Preparing. Trusting the work already in motion.

Garrick at the Gate became a man obsessed with the daily dance of coin. He tracked cash now not just by day but by hour, by source, by the particular purse it came from. His reports grew into small maps of monetary movement—this merchant paid in copper, that family in silver, the baker always in odd

combinations that suggested he was counting out what remained after his own expenses.

"We're not bleeding," Garrick reported at the week's end. "But we're not clotting either. Money's moving through us faster than it's settling."

"Then we slow the outflow," Lady De said. "Beatrice, how much flexibility remains in our payment schedule?"

Beatrice consulted her careful calendar, each supplier marked in different colored ink, each due date circled with notes about relationships, histories, wiggle room.

"The feed merchant will wait another week if we ask. The lumber order for coop repairs can be halved without compromising structure. And I believe—" she paused, choosing words carefully, "—that if we explain our situation honestly to the chandler, he may offer extended terms as well."

"He'll want something in return," Magnus warned.

"Referrals," Beatrice said simply. "I'll send the new farmers his way. He's been trying to build his customer base. A fair trade."

This was her art—understanding that business relationships were not transactions but conversations,

each payment a sentence in an ongoing dialogue. Break the dialogue, and you break the trust. Honor it, even when honoring it required creativity, and the conversation continued.

The Warehouse Master [INVENTORY] arrived with his inventory report, the Sacrifice Counter [COST OF GOODS SOLD] close behind. Together they represented the physical goods the kingdom held and the cost of transforming those goods into sales. Every egg counted. Every bag of feed tracked. Every calculation of cost-of-goods-sold precisely documented.

"Stock levels are healthy," the Warehouse Master reported. "Perhaps too healthy. We're holding more inventory than usual because sales have softened."

"Which means cash is tied up in shells instead of circulating," the Sacrifice Counter added. "Every unsold egg is money waiting to become money."

Queen Verity nodded slowly. This was the balance sheet reality—inventory was an asset, yes, but an asset that consumed cash until it converted to revenue. Too much inventory meant too little liquidity. The kingdom was egg-rich and coin-cautious.

* * *

Callum the Relentless adjusted his collection routes. Instead of covering the full territory each day, he now concentrated on accounts most likely to pay promptly, building small victories that could compound.

The merchants who'd always paid on time received extra attention—a moment of genuine conversation, a question about their children, a comment on how much the kingdom appreciated their reliability. The slower payers received something different: not pressure, but presence. Callum appeared at their doors more frequently, always pleasant, always understanding, but always there. A gentle reminder that debts were remembered.

"Three accounts paid in full yesterday," he reported. "Two more committed to partial payments by month's end."

"Good," Lady De said. "What about the rest?"

"Working on them." His jaw tightened slightly. "The Andersons are struggling. Their crop came in short. I didn't push."

"Right call. Note it. We'll check back in a season."

The Deserters [BAD DEBT]—those accounts that would never pay, the bad debt that every kingdom eventually accumulated—were thankfully few. But

Callum kept a quiet list, shared only with Magnus and Queen Verity. Some promises turned to smoke. The wise kingdom accounted for smoke.

This was the balance Callum walked daily—relentless in pursuit, but wise enough to know when pressure became cruelty. Some debts needed chasing. Some needed time. The skill was knowing which was which.

* * *

Meanwhile, the Herald of Honest Eggs [MARKETING & MESSAGING] took to the square with renewed purpose.

He did not mention Crestfall. Did not compare prices or quality or claim superiority. He simply did what he had always done, but more.

"Seventeen years," he announced to the morning crowds, his voice carrying across cobblestones worn smooth by generations of market traffic. "Seventeen years we've served this kingdom. Your grandmothers bought our eggs. Your children will buy them for their children. Because some things don't change." He held up an egg, turning it in the light. "Care. Consistency. Trust."

People listened. Not everyone—some walked past, distracted or indifferent or already loyal to the red wagon. But enough stopped. Enough nodded. Enough remembered.

"They're not asking what makes us better," the Herald told Lady De afterward. "They're asking what makes us ours. And I keep showing them."

Pip recorded it all. The cash reports, the collection notes, the supplier negotiations, the Herald's speeches and the crowd's responses. His journal grew fat with detail, each page a thread in the larger tapestry of what was actually happening versus what might seem to be happening if you only looked at surface numbers.

No proclamations issued against rivals. No panic pricing. No desperate discounts that would teach customers to wait for desperation before buying.

Just steady work.

* * *

The Oracles [FINANCIAL RATIOS] delivered their ratio analysis on the third day.

There were three of them—triplets, some said, though they looked nothing alike. They dealt in the mathematics of meaning: ratios that compared one number to another and revealed truths that neither number could show alone.

"Current ratio: 2.1," the first Oracle announced. "For every coin you owe in the short term, you possess 2.1 coins to pay it. Healthy. Perhaps overly cautious."

"Quick ratio: 1.4," the second Oracle continued. "Excluding inventory—those eggs waiting to sell—you still hold 1.4 coins per coin owed. You are not dependent on sales to meet immediate obligations."

"Debt-to-equity: 0.3," the third Oracle finished. "For every coin the kingdom owns outright, you have borrowed only three-tenths of a coin. Conservative. Almost timid."

The King studied the numbers. "This sounds like good news."

"It is good news for stability," the first Oracle said. "It is less good news for growth. You have capacity to borrow. Room to leverage. But you have chosen not to."

"Is that criticism?" Queen Verity asked, her voice neutral but sharp.

"It is observation," the Oracle replied. "The Moneylender Lord [BANK/LENDER] would see a kingdom that has been careful. Perhaps too careful. A kingdom that could afford to take risks but has preferred safety."

Lady De filed this away. The ratios confirmed what she suspected: the kingdom was healthy, but health alone would not defeat Crestfall. They needed either patience—waiting for Michlen's aggressive spending to exhaust itself—or creativity—finding ways to grow without borrowing.

Or both.

She smiled as the reports came in at week's end, spreading them across her desk like cards in a game she was slowly learning to read.

"Let the books speak," she said to no one in particular, or perhaps to the egg still sitting on her desk, patient witness to everything. "They always do."

* * *

Sidebar Note from Kari: This is the part most people skip—the unsexy middle where nobody's launching anything or celebrating anything or even panicking interestingly. Just folks doing their jobs. Which is

exactly why most businesses fall apart. They forget that daily is the revolution.

Chapter 4

Kindness on the Scales

The idea did not come from Lady De alone.

It began, as many good ideas do, with a complaint.

The Herald of Honest Eggs returned from the market square one afternoon with frustration written across his face like a poorly erased ledger entry.

"They're not just selling eggs anymore," he reported to whoever would listen. "They've set up a cooking demonstration. Some fellow in a tall hat making omelets right there in the square. The smell reaches halfway across the market before you even see their wagon."

Lady De looked up from her inventory reports. "They're selling the experience, not just the product."

"And it's working. People are gathering. Even people who came to buy from us are drifting over to watch."

Silence settled over the counting hall. The Herald had identified a problem, but problems without solutions were just complaints dressed up in observations.

Then Pip the Daily Scribe spoke—quietly, almost to himself.

"If they can cook, we can cook. But we don't have to copy. We could do it differently. Make it ours."

Lady De turned to face him. "Go on."

Pip flushed slightly, unaccustomed to being the center of attention. "I mean—Crestfall is doing demonstrations. Showy. Professional. The tall hat, the fancy technique. But we're not them. We're—" he searched for the word, "—neighborly. What if we did something that felt like community instead of performance?"

"Weekly omelets," the Herald said slowly, the idea taking shape as he spoke. "Free samples. We cook them right there, fresh herbs, simple preparation. Nothing fancy—just good. And the smell..."

"The smell reaches everyone within forty feet before they've even decided to stop walking," Delia finished, a grin spreading across her face.

* * *

The second idea came from an unexpected source.

Lady Continuance [STATEMENT OF EQUITY], the kingdom's Historian, rarely attended the morning courts. Her domain was the Statement of Equity—the long story of how the kingdom's wealth had accumulated over time, the retained earnings that represented years of careful stewardship. She dealt in decades, not days.

But she appeared that afternoon, drawn by rumors of strategic discussions.

"I've been thinking about legacy," she said, settling into a chair that seemed to have been waiting for her. "About what makes people loyal to a kingdom over generations. It's not just quality. It's memory. Association. The feeling that your history is woven into theirs."

"Go on," the King said, intrigued.

"Children," Lady Continuance said simply. "When children have happy memories associated with a place, they become adults who return. Their parents become loyal because their children are delighted. And delight—" she smiled, "—is remarkably inexpensive to create."

"What are you proposing?" Queen Verity asked.

"An egg-coloring contest. Open to all ages, but especially children, because children drag parents, and parents carry purses. We provide the dyes, the eggs, the prizes. They provide the joy and the word-of-mouth."

Elowen Mapwright was already sketching numbers. "Dyes can be traded for—the chandler makes pigments. He'd welcome the exposure. Eggs are inventory we already hold. Prizes... what kind of prizes?"

"Our best specimens," Lady Continuance said. "Set aside the most beautiful eggs as awards. It costs us only what we would have sold anyway, but it creates ceremony. Ritual. Memory."

The court murmured approval. Two ideas now, both rooted in the kingdom's existing resources, both designed to create experience rather than just transaction.

* * *

The third idea came from the most unlikely voice of all.

Theo the Tally rarely spoke in full court. His work—ensuring that every debit matched every credit, that

the trial balance balanced before formal statements were prepared—was essential but invisible. The accounting equivalent of checking that all the doors were locked before bed.

But he had been listening. And somewhere in his methodical mind, something unexpected had taken shape.

"The chickens," he said.

Everyone turned.

Theo cleared his throat, visibly uncomfortable with the attention. "I was thinking about assets. About what we have that others don't. And I kept coming back to the chickens. Not the eggs—the chickens themselves. They're... they have personality. Some of them. The way they walk. The sounds they make."

"Are you suggesting we sell the chickens?" Magnus Vaultwell asked, confused.

"No. I'm suggesting we... display them." Theo's face had gone pink, but he pressed on. "A fashion show. Chickens in costumes. It sounds absurd—I know it sounds absurd—but absurdity draws attention. And attention, properly channeled..."

"Becomes revenue," Delia finished, her eyes widening. "A chicken fashion show. Bold enough to make the whole kingdom cluck."

"The seamstress guild," Beatrice said suddenly. "They've been asking for opportunities to showcase their apprentices' work. What if we partnered with them? They provide the costumes, we provide the chickens and the venue. They get exposure, we get spectacle."

"And spectacle," the Herald added, beginning to laugh, "is the one thing Crestfall can't copy without looking desperate."

* * *

Lady De stood before the King and Queen that evening, the three proposals arranged before her like offerings on an altar.

"I have a scathingly brilliant idea," she said. "Actually, the court has three."

She explained each initiative—the omelets born from Pip's quiet observation and the Herald's frustration, the coloring contest from Lady Continuance's understanding of legacy, the fashion show from Theo's unexpected creative spark.

"None of these came from me alone," she said. "They came from people doing their jobs, paying attention, and being willing to speak up. That's what makes this court different from Crestfall. Prince Michlen makes decisions alone. We make them together."

Queen Verity studied the budget projections Elowen had prepared. "Affordable. We trade eggs for vegetables with the market gardeners, eliminating food costs for the omelet station. The chandler provides dyes in exchange for referrals. The seamstress guild contributes labor for exposure. No debt required."

"And the ratios?" the King asked.

"Unchanged," Lady De said. "These initiatives use resources we already have, relationships we've already built, and creativity that costs nothing but time. We're not borrowing to compete. We're being ourselves—louder."

The Herald drafted announcements in his mind, already composing the phrases that would spread through the market. "They'll be scrambling for more," he said, allowing himself a terrible pun.

Whispers would spread from the rival camp—their scouts had noticed the seamstresses visiting, the

unusual herb orders, the way Pip had been measuring the market square for something he wouldn't explain. Speculation flourished. Concern mounted.

Lady De ignored it all.

"Let's be better," she said. "Not louder."

The King smiled. "You just said we're being ourselves louder."

"Better and louder, then. But never desperate. Never mean. Never pretending to be something we're not."

* * *

Sidebar Note from Kari: Kindness as strategy is not the same as niceness as weakness. Kindness has teeth. It just keeps them clean.

Chapter 5

When the Market Answers

The market came alive.

Not slowly, the way spring comes after a long winter, but suddenly, the way a room changes when someone starts laughing and can't stop. One moment the square was its usual morning self—merchants arranging wares, early shoppers moving with purpose, the red wagon gleaming in its corner like an ambitious wound. The next moment, smell.

The omelet station announced itself before anyone saw it.

Fresh eggs hitting hot iron, herbs releasing their green souls into the air, the particular sizzle that speaks directly to the part of the brain where hunger lives. Within minutes, a crowd had formed. Within an hour, the cook had run out of eggs twice and Garrick had dispatched runners for reinforcement.

"They're not just tasting," the cook reported during a brief pause for breath. "They're asking. How do you get them so fluffy? What's in the seasoning? Where can I buy eggs this good?"

"Tell them," Lady De said, stationed nearby with clipboard in hand, tallying interactions she knew she'd want to analyze later.

"I am! And then I point to our main stall, and they go there."

The conversion math was working. Smell became curiosity. Curiosity became taste. Taste became purchase. The Herald had been right about the forty-foot radius—the aroma created a net that caught passersby before they'd consciously decided to stop.

* * *

The egg-coloring contest drew a different crowd—younger, louder, more likely to spill dye on themselves and each other and occasionally on passing adults who had the misfortune of clean aprons.

Children clustered around wooden tables, tongues out in concentration, painting eggs in colors nature never intended. Some attempted portraits of family members with varying degrees of anatomical accuracy. Some went abstract, creating swirls and patterns that seemed to mean something even if no one could say what. One small boy had decided his

egg should be entirely black, and was working on his third coat with the dedication of a Flemish master.

"That one's either a future artist or a future mortician," the Herald observed, watching the black egg slowly disappear into its own darkness.

"Either way, his mother's already bought two dozen," Delia noted. "And her neighbor's ordered for next week."

Lady Continuance had been right about memory. The children would remember this day. They would associate eggs—and this kingdom—with joy, with color, with the particular satisfaction of creating something from nothing. And in ten years, twenty years, they would return with their own children, because that's how loyalty really worked: not through transactions, but through stories people told themselves about who they were and where they belonged.

* * *

The real magic, though, happened at the fashion show.

The seamstress apprentices had outdone themselves. Chickens strutted down a makeshift runway wearing

everything from tiny ballgowns to miniature military uniforms to one astonishing creation that could only be described as "baroque nightmare with feathers." The crowd roared approval at each new entry. Children shrieked with joy. Adults who had arrived skeptical found themselves cheering for a rooster in a waistcoat.

Some chickens strutted proudly, clearly understanding they were the center of attention and rising magnificently to the occasion. Others looked profoundly confused, their small chicken brains unable to process why they were wearing trousers. Both reactions delighted the crowd equally.

"Most entertaining thing I've seen in years," one elderly man told Lady De, wiping tears from his eyes. "And I lived through the Great Goat Incident of '04."

"We aim to please," Lady De said, watching a hen in a tiny crown process past with all the dignity of actual royalty.

From across the square, she could see the Crestfall wagon. Its operators stood idle, watching the crowds flow toward the fashion show with expressions that shifted between confusion and concern. They had not anticipated this. They had come prepared to compete

on price and flash, and instead found themselves outflanked by absurdity and joy.

* * *

But even as the laughter rang out, Delia was watching the numbers. Counting. Always counting.

That evening, the court gathered in the counting hall as candles were lit and the day's truths were finally tallied.

Pip spread his attendance records across the table. "Omelet station: approximately three hundred participants over six hours. Egg-coloring contest: one hundred twelve registered entrants, plus an estimated two hundred observers. Fashion show: standing room only, overflow into adjacent streets."

"Sales?" Garrick asked, the question that mattered most.

"Up forty-three percent over the same day last month." Pip consulted his notes. "More importantly, new customers accounted for nearly a third of purchases. People who hadn't bought from us in weeks. Some who'd never bought from us at all."

Elowen compared actual expenses against projections. "Omelet station ran slightly over budget due to demand—but the margin on eggs sold easily covered the difference. Contest came in exactly as planned. Fashion show costs offset entirely by the seamstress guild's sponsorship contribution."

"So two initiatives exceeded expectations," Magnus summarized, "and one performed exactly as modeled."

"Which means we can scale the winners and maintain the steady performer," Beatrice added, already making notes about future supplier negotiations. "The herb merchant will want a longer-term arrangement if we're doing weekly omelets. I can work with that."

The Oracles, who had observed from the edges of the festivities, offered their perspective.

"The ratios will shift," the first Oracle said. "Inventory conversion improved. Receivables may actually shorten as customers pay more promptly—loyalty tends to accelerate payment."

"We should run the numbers again in a month," the second Oracle suggested. "See if the Moneylender Lord would view us differently now."

"Or whether we still need him at all," the third Oracle finished.

Lady De listened to it all, letting the information settle like sediment after a river runs high.

"What about the competition?" the King asked.

"They cut prices again today," the Herald reported. "Announced it right as the fashion show started. Nobody heard."

"Will they keep cutting?"

"Probably. For a while." Lady De finally spoke, her voice thoughtful. "But there's a floor to how low prices can go before you're losing money on every sale. They'll hit it eventually, and then they'll have to decide: build something real, or move on."

"And us?"

"We keep being us." She picked up the egg—finally, after all these weeks, feeling like she understood what it represented. "Omelets next week. Contest monthly. Fashion show quarterly, maybe, if the chickens don't start demanding union representation."

Light laughter rippled through the court.

"We learned something today," Lady De continued. "Events work. Joy works. Being ourselves works. But not every idea will be a firework. The coloring contest was nice—solid, dependable, worthwhile. Not spectacular. And that's fine. Not everything has to explode. Some things just need to keep burning."

She set the egg down in the center of the table, where it caught the candlelight and glowed.

"Good," she said. "Now we know."

* * *

Later that night, as the counting hall emptied and the kingdom settled into well-earned rest, the Prophet found Lady De still at her desk.

"You're not celebrating," the Prophet observed.

"I'm thinking," Lady De said. "Today was good. But Crestfall isn't going away. Prince Michlen isn't going to watch us succeed and decide to be gracious about it. If anything, today probably made things worse for them—which means they'll get more desperate."

"You're expecting escalation."

"I'm preparing for it." Lady De looked up, her eyes tired but clear. "The loan analysis—let's continue it.

Not because I think we'll need to borrow, but because I want to know exactly what we can afford if things get harder. I want to know our own strength before it's tested."

The Prophet nodded slowly. "And if Michlen does something truly desperate?"

Lady De considered this. Somewhere out there, in the kingdom of Crestfall, a young prince was probably pacing his own halls, wondering how omelets and fancy chickens had outflanked his carefully calculated price war. He would not take it well. Pride rarely did.

"Then we respond with what we're good at," she said finally. "Good numbers. Good people. Good work. And maybe—" she allowed herself a small smile, "—a few more chickens in fancy hats."

* * *

Outside, the kingdom settled into evening rhythms. Somewhere, a red wagon sat quiet in its corner of the market, its gold letters dimmed by shadows. Its operators would regroup, recalculate, perhaps return with new tactics.

And the Court of Accounts would be ready. Not because they'd been chasing chickens.

Because they'd been counting eggs.

Chapter 6

The Foxes in the Night

The screaming started before dawn.

Not human screaming—worse. The sound chickens make when death arrives on four legs with teeth and intention. Lady De was out of bed and running before her mind fully caught up with her body, feet bare on cold stone, heart already counting losses she hadn't yet seen.

The eastern coop was chaos.

Feathers everywhere—drifting in the torchlight like snow falling wrong, like the air itself had shattered. Workers shouted and swung lanterns, casting wild shadows across a scene that would haunt Lady De's dreams for months: foxes, three of them, sleek and rust-colored and impossibly bold, tearing through hens that had been alive and laying and named just hours before.

"Drive them out!" someone bellowed, and the workers surged forward with rakes and shovels and whatever they'd grabbed in their own panicked waking. The foxes scattered—not fleeing exactly, but retreating,

like soldiers who'd accomplished their mission and saw no reason to die for extra credit.

They slipped through a hole in the fence that hadn't been there yesterday.

Lady De stood in the doorway of the coop, her hand pressed against the frame, her breath coming in short gasps that had nothing to do with exertion. Around her, workers began the grim work of assessment. Counting bodies. Checking survivors. Tallying what had been lost.

Seventeen.

Seventeen hens dead. Three more injured badly enough that mercy would be kinder than medicine. The rooster called Brigadier—proud, ridiculous, beloved—had died defending his flock, his body found closest to the hole in the fence, feathers still raised in defiance.

Twenty birds. Just like that. Gone.

* * *

The court assembled at first light, though no one had slept after the attack. They gathered in the counting

hall with shadows under their eyes and grief sitting heavy on their shoulders.

Pip the Daily Scribe [THE JOURNAL] recorded everything, his quill moving steadily even as his hand wanted to shake. This was his purpose—to capture truth, especially when truth was terrible. He noted the number of dead, the location of the breach, the timing of the attack, the behavior of the foxes.

"Foxes don't act like that," the Warehouse Master [INVENTORY] said, his voice rough. "Not wild ones. They're cautious. They take one bird and run. These..." He shook his head. "These were hunting for sport. For damage."

"Or they were sent," Magnus Vaultwell [THE GENERAL LEDGER] said quietly.

The words hung in the air like smoke.

"We don't know that," Lady De said, though her voice lacked conviction. "Foxes are foxes. Sometimes they go mad. Sometimes they're just hungry."

"The fence was cut," Garrick at the Gate [CASH FLOW] reported. He'd examined it himself at dawn, running his fingers along edges too clean to be accident. "Not chewed. Not weathered. Cut. Someone made that hole."

Silence fell over the court. The kind of silence that precedes storms.

Queen Verity of the Ledgers [THE BALANCE SHEET] spoke first, her voice as calm and unmovable as ever. "Then we have two problems. The first is grief—we have lost animals that were in our care, and we will mourn them properly. The second is arithmetic—we have lost productive assets, and we must understand what that means for the kingdom's position."

It was a cold way to frame tragedy. It was also exactly right. Grief and math. Both true. Both necessary.

"The loss represents approximately eight percent of our laying capacity," the Sacrifice Counter [COST OF GOODS SOLD] reported, having already run the numbers. "At current egg prices and demand levels, that translates to—"

"We know what it translates to," Lady De said, more sharply than she intended. She closed her eyes, breathed, tried again. "I'm sorry. I know you're doing your job. I know we need the numbers. I just..."

She didn't finish. She didn't need to. Everyone in the room understood.

The Brigadier had been her favorite. She'd never admitted it—a steward shouldn't play favorites—but

everyone knew. He'd followed her on market rounds sometimes, strutting beside her like a small, feathered bodyguard. She'd named him herself, back when he was just a chick with more attitude than sense.

"We'll mourn properly," the King said, his voice gentle but firm. "And then we'll rebuild. That's what Eggerton does."

* * *

They held a service that afternoon.

It felt strange, perhaps, to hold a funeral for chickens. Other kingdoms might have laughed. But Eggerton was not other kingdoms, and these were not just chickens—they were members of the operation, contributors to the kingdom's prosperity, living creatures who had been in their care and were now gone.

The Herald of Honest Eggs [MARKETING] spoke words that somehow managed to be both solemn and warm. He named each bird that had died, described their personalities, acknowledged their service. The workers who'd known them best added their own memories—this one always laid double-yolks, that one escaped

constantly, this one had a vendetta against the color blue for reasons no one ever understood.

Laughter mixed with tears. That was Eggerton's way.

Lady De stood at the front, an egg in her palm—one of the last the Brigadier's flock had produced. She didn't speak. She didn't need to. Her presence said everything: I was here. I saw. I will remember.

After the service, the kingdom didn't scatter back to work immediately. They lingered. They talked. They shared meals and memories and the particular comfort that comes from grieving together instead of alone.

This, too, was a kind of strength.

* * *

That evening, the court reconvened to address the second problem: the math.

The Prophet [CASH FLOW FORECAST] had updated her projections. "The loss of laying capacity will reduce egg revenue by approximately twelve percent over the next quarter, assuming we don't replace the birds. If we do replace them, we're looking at significant capital expenditure—new hens aren't

cheap, and they won't reach full production for several months."

"How much?" Lady De asked.

"To restore full capacity? Between purchasing birds, reinforcing all the coops against future attacks, and covering the revenue gap during the transition..." The Prophet consulted her scrolls. "We're looking at roughly what we'd projected as our entire discretionary budget for the next two quarters."

"Which we don't have," Garrick said flatly.

"Which we don't have liquid," the Prophet corrected. "We have assets. We have receivables. We have the revenue from the initiatives. But cash on hand? Not enough. Not for this."

The Oracles [FINANCIAL RATIOS] exchanged glances. The first one spoke: "Our current ratio drops to 1.4 if we absorb this loss without borrowing. Still healthy. But our quick ratio falls below 1.0, which means we'd be dependent on selling inventory to meet short-term obligations."

"Dependent on selling eggs," Elowen Mapwright [CHART OF ACCOUNTS] translated, "from chickens we no longer have."

"The Moneylender Lord," Queen Verity said. Not a question. An observation.

Lady De had known it was coming. Had prepared for it, even—all those weeks of ratio analysis, of understanding their own position, of knowing what they could afford before anyone asked. But knowing you might need to borrow and actually needing to borrow were different things.

"We have options," she said slowly. "We could scale back the initiatives. Reduce staff. Cut costs across the board and try to absorb the loss gradually."

"We could," Sir Ludo Quarterly [PROFIT & LOSS] agreed. "But that's how you turn a crisis into a collapse. You cut muscle thinking it's fat. You sacrifice the things that were working to preserve the things that weren't. I've seen kingdoms do it. They never recover the same way."

"So we borrow," the King said.

"So we consider borrowing," Lady De corrected. "Carefully. With full knowledge of what we're taking on and why." She looked around the room, meeting each pair of eyes in turn. "This isn't defeat. This is using every tool available. We know our numbers. We

know our strength. We know exactly what we can handle. That's not weakness—that's wisdom."

The Prophet nodded slowly. "I can have a full proposal ready for the Moneylender Lord within three days. Terms we'd accept. Limits we won't cross. A repayment schedule that doesn't strangle us."

"Do it," Lady De said. "And while you're preparing that, the rest of us prepare for something else."

"What?" Garrick asked.

Lady De's expression shifted—still grieving, still tired, but with something harder underneath. Something that had been forged in the night's fire.

"We don't know for certain that Crestfall sent those foxes. We may never know. But we know this: someone wanted us to panic. Someone wanted us to collapse into fear and blame and desperate decisions." She picked up the egg from her pocket—her constant companion, her reminder. "We're not going to give them that. We're going to mourn our dead, count our losses, secure our coops, and keep being exactly who we are. The omelets continue. The contests continue. The joy continues."

"And if they attack again?" Callum the Relentless [ACCOUNTS RECEIVABLE] asked.

"Then we count those losses too. And we keep going." Lady De set the egg on the table, where it caught the lamplight. "Crestfall wants us to chase chickens—to run around in circles, reacting to every threat, exhausting ourselves with fear. But that's not what Eggerton does."

She looked at the egg. At the court. At the kingdom that had trusted her to lead them through whatever came.

"We count eggs. Even when counting hurts. Even when the numbers tell us things we don't want to hear. We count, and we plan, and we rebuild."

The court was silent. Then, one by one, they nodded.

This was Eggerton. This was who they were.

* * *

Miles away, in the dim halls of Crestfall, Prince Michlen received the report with something that might have been satisfaction.

"Twenty birds," his agent confirmed. "Their eastern coop. Significant damage."

"Good." Michlen stared out his window toward the east, toward the kingdom he'd been taught to envy

since childhood. "Let them feel what loss tastes like. Let them scramble and panic and make mistakes."

"Your Majesty," Silas the Ledgerkeeper [CRESTFALL'S GENERAL LEDGER] spoke from his corner, where he'd been pretending to review documents. "This kind of action... if it were ever traced back to us..."

"It won't be." Michlen waved a hand dismissively. "Foxes are foxes. Accidents happen. No one can prove anything."

"That's not—" Silas stopped himself. Tried a different approach. "Even if we're never blamed, Your Majesty, this doesn't solve our fundamental problem. Our costs are still too high. Our prices are still too low. We're bleeding coin every day we maintain this strategy."

"Then we bleed," Michlen said. "Until they bleed more."

"But the ledgers—"

"Damn the ledgers!" Michlen spun from the window, his face flushed with something between anger and desperation. "I'm tired of ledgers. I'm tired of numbers. I'm tired of being told what we can't afford and can't do and can't achieve. My father spent his whole life reading ledgers, and what did it get him? A kingdom that survived but never thrived. A legacy of

adequacy." He jabbed a finger toward the east. "They don't have better numbers. They don't have smarter people. They have luck and they have reputation and now they have twenty fewer chickens. That's progress."

Silas looked at the young king—really looked, for perhaps the first time since the coronation. He saw the hunger, the insecurity, the desperate need to be more than his father had been. He saw a man who mistook destruction for creation, who thought tearing down was the same as building up.

He saw a disaster still unfolding.

"Yes, Your Majesty," Silas said quietly, and returned to his documents.

But later that night, in his small office overlooking the courtyard, he opened a new journal—separate from the official ledgers, hidden beneath a loose floorboard—and began to write.

A record of what was really happening. A chronicle of choices made and consequences coming. A truth that someone, someday, might need to read.

Silas didn't know yet what he would do with these pages. He only knew he couldn't not write them.

The numbers had to go somewhere. Even if no one wanted to see them.

* * *

Sidebar Note from Kari: This is the chapter that separates the businesses that survive from the businesses that don't. Not because of the attack—attacks happen. Markets shift. Disasters strike. The difference is what you do after. Do you chase the chaos? Or do you count what's left and build from there?

Chapter 7

What the Ledger Holds

Three days after the attack, the counting hall looked like a war room.

Maps covered every surface—not Elowen's usual budget projections, but physical layouts of every coop, every fence line, every potential point of entry. The Warehouse Master [INVENTORY] had conducted a full audit of remaining birds, their ages, their laying patterns, their health. The Sacrifice Counter [COST OF GOODS SOLD] had recalculated production capacity down to the individual egg.

This was what Eggerton did in crisis: it counted.

"Current laying stock: one hundred and sixty-three birds," the Warehouse Master reported. "Down from one hundred and eighty-three before the attack. Of those remaining, approximately one hundred and forty are in peak production. The rest are either too young, too old, or recovering from stress."

"Stress affects laying?" the King asked.

"Significantly, Your Majesty. Hens that witnessed the attack may not produce normally for weeks. Some

never fully recover." The Warehouse Master's voice was steady, professional, but his eyes betrayed the weight of what he was describing. "We're not just counting the dead. We're counting the wounded we can't see."

Lady De absorbed this. Another loss to add to the ledger—one that wouldn't show up in the body count but would echo through production reports for months.

"The Prophet has updated the forecasts," she said. "Let's hear them."

The Prophet [CASH FLOW FORECAST] rose, her scrolls unfurled across the main table. Unlike her usual projections—neat lines extending into an orderly future—these showed branches, contingencies, multiple paths depending on choices not yet made.

"Three scenarios," she began. "First: we do nothing. We absorb the loss, reduce production expectations, and hope the remaining birds compensate over time. This path requires no capital outlay but extends our recovery to eighteen months minimum. Our market position erodes as we can't meet demand. Crestfall gains ground."

"Unacceptable," Sir Ludo Quarterly [PROFIT & LOSS] muttered.

"Second scenario: partial replacement. We purchase enough birds to maintain basic operations—say, thirty hens—and focus on defending our core business. Capital requirement is moderate. Recovery time drops to eight months. We hold position but don't advance."

"And the third?" Queen Verity [THE BALANCE SHEET] asked, though her tone suggested she already knew.

"Full replacement plus fortification. Fifty new birds to restore capacity and provide buffer against future losses. Complete security upgrades to all coops—reinforced fencing, night watch rotation, alarm systems. This is the aggressive path." The Prophet paused. "It's also the most expensive. We would need to approach the Moneylender Lord."

The room fell quiet. Borrowing wasn't shameful in Eggerton—the court understood that debt was a tool, not a sin—but it wasn't undertaken lightly either. Every loan was a promise made to the future, a claim against earnings not yet realized.

"What are the numbers?" Lady De asked.

The Oracles [FINANCIAL RATIOS] stepped forward, moving in their usual eerie synchronization. The first one spoke:

"Under scenario three, assuming standard lending terms, your debt-to-equity ratio rises from 0.3 to approximately 0.6. Still healthy. Still within the range that signals responsible leverage rather than desperation."

"Interest coverage remains strong," the second Oracle added. "Your operating income can service the debt three times over, even with reduced production during the transition period."

"The Moneylender Lord will approve this loan," the third Oracle concluded. "The question is not whether you can borrow. The question is whether you should."

Beatrice the Patient [ACCOUNTS PAYABLE] raised a hand. "I've spoken with our suppliers. The feed merchant will extend credit during the rebuilding period—he knows we're good for it. The lumber supplier has offered materials at cost for the coop reinforcements. Our relationships are holding."

"Because we've paid fairly," Callum the Relentless [ACCOUNTS RECEIVABLE] added. "Because we've honored our debts and kept our word. That's not

nothing. That's capital you can't put on a balance sheet."

Lady De looked around the room. Every face was tired. Every face was grieving. But every face was also working—calculating, planning, finding paths forward instead of dwelling on paths closed.

"We're not going to make this decision today," she said. "But I want everyone to understand something. Whatever we choose, we choose from knowledge, not fear. We know our ratios. We know our relationships. We know what we can afford and what we can't." She picked up an egg from the table—there was always an egg now, a habit that had become ritual. "Crestfall wanted us to panic. To make desperate choices in the dark. Instead, we lit candles and opened ledgers. That's already a victory."

"A small one," the King said gently.

"They're all small," Lady De replied. "Until you count them up and realize they've become something large."

* * *

While the court planned, the kingdom worked.

Workers reinforced fences with whatever materials they had on hand—not permanent solutions, but immediate ones. Night watches were organized, volunteers taking shifts with lanterns and loud voices to scare off anything that might approach. The surviving chickens were moved to the most secure coops, crowded but safe.

And through it all, the initiatives continued.

The omelet station opened that Saturday as scheduled. The cook worked with fewer eggs—smaller portions, longer waits—but he worked. The smell still drifted across the market square, still drew crowds, still converted curious onlookers into loyal customers.

"We're short on supply," the Herald of Honest Eggs [MARKETING] announced to the gathered crowd, his voice carrying clearly across the cobblestones. "Our coops were attacked. We lost good birds. But we're still here. We're still cooking. And we're still grateful for every one of you who chooses Eggerton eggs."

He didn't mention Crestfall. Didn't accuse. Didn't inflame.

He didn't need to. The crowd understood. Word had spread—it always did—about the foxes, the cut fence,

the suspicious timing. People drew their own conclusions.

And they drew closer to the omelet station, not away from it.

"Two dozen," a woman said, pressing coins into a worker's hand. "For my family. And tell Lady De we're sorry for her loss."

"A dozen for me," said the man behind her. "And I'll take whatever you have left at the end of the day. Don't want them going to waste."

"Same," said the next customer. And the next. And the next.

By noon, they had sold everything. By afternoon, they had a waiting list for next week.

Grief, it turned out, could be a kind of currency too. Not exploited—never that—but acknowledged, shared, transformed into solidarity. Eggerton had been wounded, and its people had responded by drawing closer, not pulling away.

* * *

Across the border, Silas the Ledgerkeeper watched.

He had his sources—merchants who traveled between kingdoms, workers who whispered news across fence lines, the quiet network of people who paid attention to things their rulers ignored. Through them, he learned what Eggerton was doing.

Not panicking. Not retaliating. Not collapsing into blame and accusation.

Counting. Planning. Rebuilding.

Continuing.

He added the observations to his hidden journal, the one beneath the floorboard, the truth that Michlen would never read:

Day four after the attack. Eggerton's market presence unchanged. Omelet station operational despite reduced supply. Crowd response: increased loyalty, not diminished. Herald's speech positioned loss as shared tragedy, not competitive weakness. No accusations against Crestfall—publicly. Privately, suspicions spreading. Our strategy has wounded them but not weakened them. Unclear if this distinction matters to His Majesty.

He set down his quill and stared at the words. The distinction mattered enormously, of course. Wounding an enemy that recovered stronger was

worse than not striking at all. It was the kind of mistake that looked like progress while actually accelerating defeat.

But Michlen didn't want to hear about distinctions. Michlen wanted to hear about damage.

"The coops are vulnerable," the agent had reported that morning, practically preening. "Another strike could finish them."

"Then strike again," Michlen had ordered. "Different location this time. Make them spread their defenses thin."

Silas had said nothing. There was nothing to say that would be heard.

But later, walking through Crestfall's own market—quieter now, fewer merchants, fewer customers, fewer coins changing hands—he noticed something he hadn't seen before.

Or rather, something he hadn't let himself see.

The people weren't just tired. They were hungry. Not starving—not yet—but lean in a way that spoke of meals skipped and portions halved. The best eggs went to Eggerton's market, sold at prices that lost money with every transaction. What remained for

Crestfall's own tables were the seconds, the smalls, the ones not pretty enough for export.

"Sacrifice," Michlen had called it. "Our people will understand."

But understanding and accepting were different things. And Silas saw, in the eyes of the merchants and the farmers and the mothers counting coins that didn't quite reach, the beginning of something that looked less like sacrifice and more like abandonment.

He returned to his office and wrote that down too.

The ledger was getting heavy.

* * *

One week after the attack, the court gathered to make its decision.

The Prophet had prepared three formal proposals—one for each scenario—complete with projected cash flows, repayment schedules, and risk assessments. The Oracles had stress-tested each path against various market conditions. Magnus Vaultwell [THE GENERAL LEDGER] had reconciled every account, ensuring they knew their exact position down to the last copper coin.

"We've done our work," Lady De said, looking around the table. "Now we decide."

"Scenario three," Queen Verity said immediately. "Full replacement and fortification. The numbers support it. The relationships support it. And the alternative—slow erosion while Crestfall chips away at us—is not a future I'm willing to accept."

"Agreed," said Sir Ludo. "You don't win by playing defense forever. You stabilize, then you advance."

"The loan concerns me," Garrick at the Gate [CASH FLOW] admitted. "Not because we can't handle it—we can. But because it ties us to the Moneylender Lord's timeline, not our own."

"That's always true of borrowed money," Lady De said. "The question is whether the opportunity justifies the constraint." She paused. "I think it does."

The King had been listening quietly, as was his way. Now he spoke: "We've heard the numbers. We've heard the concerns. Is there anyone who believes we should choose differently?"

Silence.

"Then we approach the Moneylender Lord," the King said. "Not as supplicants begging for help, but as

partners proposing a sound investment. We show him what we've shown ourselves: a kingdom that knows its worth and has a plan to protect it."

"I'll prepare the presentation," the Prophet said.

"I'll verify every number twice," Magnus added.

"And I," said Lady De, standing, "will walk the market. Because that's what I do. Because you can't count what you don't see, and I need to see what we're protecting."

She slipped an egg into her pocket and headed for the door.

"Lady De," the King called after her.

She turned.

"Your father would be proud," he said quietly. "The way you've led through this. The way you've kept us steady."

Lady De's throat tightened. She hadn't thought about her father in days—too busy counting, planning, surviving. But the King's words brought him back: his hands teaching her to hold an egg properly, his voice explaining why the numbers mattered, his absolute conviction that a business run with integrity could weather any storm.

"He taught me to count," she said finally. "Everything else is just... not forgetting."

She walked out into the morning light, the egg warm in her pocket, the kingdom stirring around her.

They were wounded. They were grieving. They were in debt—or would be soon.

But they were Eggerton. And Eggerton counted eggs.

Even now. Especially now.

* * *

Sidebar Note from Kari: Borrowing money isn't failure. Borrowing money without knowing your numbers is failure. The loan doesn't define you. What you do with it does.

Chapter 8

The Cracks in Crestfall

The crops failed on a Thursday.

Not dramatically—no blight sweeping through overnight, no locusts descending in biblical fury. The failure was quieter than that. More insidious. The kind of failure that crept up slowly until suddenly everyone noticed at once.

The southern fields, which had been treated with Michlen's "enhanced fertilizers" to boost yield, simply... stopped producing. The plants were still there—green, upright, looking healthy enough from a distance. But the vegetables they bore were small, bitter, wrong. Tomatoes that tasted like metal. Corn that never quite ripened. Squash that rotted on the vine before reaching full size.

"It's the soil," the head farmer reported to the council, his hat in his hands, his voice carrying the particular weariness of a man delivering news he'd tried very hard not to believe. "Whatever was in those treatments, it didn't just boost growth. It burned out the earth. Stripped something essential. The land needs seasons to recover—maybe years."

"Years?" Michlen's voice was sharp. "We don't have years. We have a strategy to execute."

"Your Majesty, the strategy won't matter if we can't feed our own people."

Silas the Ledgerkeeper [CRESTFALL'S GENERAL LEDGER] sat in his usual corner, quill moving automatically, recording every word. He'd known this was coming—the ledgers had whispered it for weeks. The cost of the fertilizers. The unusual depletion patterns. The way certain expenditures had been classified as "investments" when they should have been classified as "gambles."

But knowing something in numbers and knowing it in ruined crops were different things.

"We'll import food," Michlen said, waving his hand as if dismissing a minor inconvenience. "Other kingdoms have surplus. We'll buy what we need."

"With what funds, Your Majesty?" Lord Pemberton asked carefully. "The treasury—"

"The treasury will recover once we've secured the Eggerton market. This is temporary."

Silas noted the phrase: "temporary." Michlen used it often. Everything was temporary—the losses, the

sacrifices, the hungry faces in the market. All temporary, all justified by a future victory that kept receding like a horizon line.

"If I may," Silas said, surprising himself by speaking, "the current treasury position does not support significant food imports. We're already operating at a deficit from the pricing strategy in Eggerton. To add import costs..."

"Then we adjust," Michlen snapped. "We find other savings. Cut other expenses."

"We've cut extensively, Your Majesty. The remaining expenses are largely essential—infrastructure, basic services, the egg operation itself."

"Then cut deeper."

The room fell silent. Even Lord Pemberton, who had learned caution, looked uncomfortable. "Cut deeper" could mean many things. Most of them bad.

Silas returned his attention to his ledger, but his mind was elsewhere. In a hidden journal beneath a floorboard. In a growing record of choices that couldn't be unchoiced, consequences that couldn't be unconsequenced.

The cracks were spreading. And Michlen refused to see them.

* * *

The whispers started that same week.

At first they were quiet—conversations that stopped when officials walked by, glances exchanged between farmers at the market, the particular silence of people who were thinking dangerous thoughts but hadn't yet found the courage to voice them.

Then, slowly, the whispers grew into murmurs. And the murmurs grew into questions.

"Have you heard about Eggerton?"

"They say the market there has omelets. Free samples. Fresh herbs."

"They say people are happy there. Can you imagine?"

"They held a funeral for their chickens. A proper service. Named each one."

"And they're rebuilding. Not blaming anyone, not crying about it. Just... rebuilding."

Silas heard the whispers because he made a point of hearing them. He walked the market each afternoon,

not as an official but as a listener—buying small items, making small talk, letting people forget he worked for the crown. It was remarkable what people would say when they thought no one important was paying attention.

"My cousin visited their market last week," a vegetable seller confided, leaning close over her diminished display of stunted produce. "Said it felt like a different world. People laughing. Children playing. Eggs you wouldn't believe—big, brown, shells like you could tap them on a rock and they'd dent the rock."

"Why doesn't she stay there, then?" Silas asked, keeping his voice neutral.

The woman's face shifted—something between longing and fear. "She's thinking about it. We all are, aren't we? Thinking about it."

"Are we?"

"Look around you." She gestured at the sparse market, the thin crowds, the merchants sitting idle because there was nothing to sell and no one to sell it to. "This isn't sacrifice anymore. This is dying slowly and calling it strategy."

Silas bought a handful of the bitter tomatoes—solidarity, even if misplaced—and continued his walk.

But her words echoed: dying slowly and calling it strategy. That was exactly what Michlen was doing. Killing Crestfall inch by inch while insisting each cut was necessary, each loss was temporary, each sacrifice would be rewarded.

The ledgers agreed. They'd agreed for months. But Michlen wouldn't read them.

* * *

The first defector left on a Sunday.

Not dramatically—no announcement, no confrontation, no burning of bridges. A family simply... didn't return from market day. Their stall sat empty on Monday. Their cottage stood silent by Tuesday. By Wednesday, their neighbors admitted what everyone already knew: they'd gone east. To Eggerton.

"They were always complainers," Lord Pemberton said at the council meeting, his dismissal almost convincing. "No great loss."

"They were also our best candlemakers," Lady Ashworth noted quietly. "Their candles supplied half the castle."

"Then we'll find other candlemakers."

"From where? Our best workers are the ones with options. And options mean they can leave."

Michlen's face darkened. "No one is leaving. One family of malcontents doesn't constitute a trend."

But by the end of the month, it was undeniably a trend. Three more families followed the candlemakers—a blacksmith, a baker, a family of weavers whose cloth had been famous throughout the region. They didn't announce their departures. They simply vanished between sunsets and sunrises, leaving behind empty homes and whispered rumors.

"Traitors," Michlen called them.

"Refugees," Silas wrote in his hidden journal.

The distinction mattered, even if Michlen couldn't see it. Traitors left to harm you. Refugees left to save themselves. The former were enemies; the latter were symptoms. And you couldn't fix a kingdom by blaming its symptoms.

You had to address the disease.

* * *

The refugees found their way to Eggerton's market on a bright Saturday morning, drawn by rumors of

omelets and colored eggs and chickens in questionable outfits.

Lady De noticed them immediately.

She'd developed an eye for newcomers over her years of market walks—something in the way they moved, simultaneously curious and cautious, taking in details that locals had long stopped seeing. These newcomers had that quality, plus something else: the particular hunger of people who'd been doing without.

She approached the weaver's family first—a mother, father, and three children ranging from barely walking to almost grown. They were standing near the omelet station, inhaling deeply, the youngest child's eyes fixed on the sizzling pan with something like reverence.

"First time in Eggerton?" Lady De asked, her voice warm but not intrusive.

The mother startled slightly. "Is it that obvious?"

"Only to someone who watches. I'm Lady De. I help run things around here."

"Hearthstone?" The father's eyes widened slightly. "The Hearthstone family?"

"Just me, these days. Though the name carries more weight than I do." She smiled. "Where are you from?"

The parents exchanged a glance—the silent communication of people who'd learned to be careful about truth. Finally, the mother spoke: "West. The other side of the hills."

"Crestfall," Lady De said, not making it a question.

The family tensed, as if expecting accusation or anger. Instead, Lady De reached into her pocket and produced an egg—warm, brown, ordinary and extraordinary at once.

"Here," she said, pressing it into the mother's hands. "For the little one. She looks like she could use a good breakfast."

The mother's eyes welled. "We didn't—we're not—"

"You're here. That's what matters." Lady De glanced at the omelet station, then back at the family. "Have you eaten?"

"We have coin," the father said quickly, pride fighting with hunger. "We can pay."

"I didn't ask if you could pay. I asked if you'd eaten."

They hadn't. Of course they hadn't. People fleeing their homes rarely packed full larders.

Lady De guided them to the omelet station, had quiet words with the cook, and within minutes the family was seated on borrowed chairs eating the first proper meal they'd had in days. The children devoured their portions and looked hopefully at the pan for seconds. The cook, without being asked, began preparing another round.

"Why?" the mother asked, watching Lady De with an expression caught between gratitude and suspicion. "We're from the kingdom that's been attacking you. That's been trying to destroy your market. You should hate us."

Lady De considered the question. It deserved a real answer.

"Your king sent foxes to kill my chickens," she said finally. "Your kingdom's policy has been to undercut our prices until we collapse. I have every reason to see you as enemies." She paused, watching the youngest child lick omelet residue from her fingers. "But you didn't send those foxes. You didn't set those prices. You're not enemies—you're people. And Eggerton doesn't punish people for the choices their rulers make."

"We left everything," the father said quietly. "Our home. Our shop. Our whole lives."

"Then you'll build new ones. Here, if you want. We could use good weavers." Lady De stood. "When you're done eating, find the Herald—tall man, loud voice, usually near the main stall. Tell him Lady De sent you. He'll help you find lodging for tonight. Tomorrow we'll talk about what comes next."

She started to walk away, then turned back.

"What made you leave? Really?"

The mother and father looked at each other. Something passed between them—permission, perhaps, or just the exhaustion of keeping secrets.

"The soil," the mother said. "They poisoned it. Trying to make things grow faster, better, more. And now nothing grows right. The vegetables taste like metal. The children were getting sick." Her voice cracked. "We couldn't watch them get sicker."

Lady De filed this away. Poisoned soil. A detail that explained much and promised worse to come.

"You're safe now," she said. "And your children will eat."

She walked back into the market, the egg in her pocket replaced by knowledge that weighed considerably more.

* * *

That evening, the court received Lady De's report with varying degrees of alarm.

"Poisoned soil," Queen Verity repeated, her voice flat. "They've destroyed their own farmland trying to outcompete us."

"Apparently so. The refugees—there are more coming, I'm told—describe crops that won't grow properly and children getting sick from what little does."

"That's..." Sir Ludo trailed off, searching for words. "That's not competition. That's self-immolation."

"It's desperation," Lady De said. "Michlen wanted results faster than sound practice could deliver. So he took shortcuts. And shortcuts in farming are—"

"Poison," Magnus Vaultwell finished quietly. "Literally, as it turns out."

The King had been silent, processing. Now he spoke: "What does this mean for us?"

"In the short term, more refugees. People fleeing a dying kingdom." Lady De paused. "In the long term... Crestfall may not survive this. Not as a functioning realm. Their treasury is depleted, their people are leaving, and now their land itself is compromised."

"You almost sound sad about it," Garrick observed.

Lady De considered this. Was she sad? Crestfall had sent foxes to kill her chickens. Had tried to destroy Eggerton's market. Had forced them into debt and grief and sleepless nights of counting and recounting their losses.

But Crestfall was also the weaver's children, hungry and scared. The candlemaker's family, vanishing between sunsets. The farmers watching their fields fail and their futures wither.

"I'm sad for the people," she said finally. "Not for Michlen. But the people didn't choose this war. They're just the ones bleeding for it."

"What do we do?" the King asked.

"We keep doing what we do. We welcome the refugees—they're workers, and we need workers. We strengthen our own position. We prepare for whatever comes next." Lady De set an egg on the table—there was always an egg now, her constant

companion, her talisman against chaos. "And we don't become what Crestfall has become. We don't sacrifice our people for pride. We don't poison our own soil for short-term gains."

"We count eggs," Queen Verity said.

"We count eggs," Lady De agreed. "Even theirs, eventually. When they're ready to be counted."

* * *

Back in Crestfall, Silas added the day's observations to his hidden journal:

Seven more families gone this week. Treasury at 23% of last year's position. Southern fields confirmed unproductive for foreseeable future. His Majesty has ordered another attack on Eggerton—targeting their western coops this time. I have documented the order but lack authority or influence to prevent it. The kingdom bleeds from wounds it keeps inflicting on itself. The refugees who reach Eggerton report being welcomed, fed, offered work. We send foxes; they send omelets. History will judge which strategy prevailed.

He set down his quill and stared at the words. History would judge, yes. But Silas was tired of waiting for history.

For the first time, he allowed himself to think the unthinkable: What if he didn't just record the disaster? What if he left it?

The thought felt like betrayal. He had served Crestfall his entire life—the old king before Michlen, and Michlen after. His family had kept ledgers here for three generations. Leaving would mean abandoning everything he'd known, everything he'd been.

But staying meant watching the kingdom destroy itself while he took careful notes on the process.

He didn't decide that night. But he didn't stop thinking about it either.

And in the morning, when he walked through the market and saw the empty stalls and the thin faces and the mothers counting coins that would never quite be enough, he thought about Eggerton's omelet station. About refugees being fed. About a Lady who carried eggs in her pockets and welcomed enemies as workers.

He thought about what it might mean to be counted among the living instead of recording the dying.

The ledger was very heavy now. Perhaps too heavy to carry much longer.

* * *

Sidebar Note from Kari: The first cracks are never the last. Watch for them. Not to celebrate someone else's failure—there's no joy in that—but because cracks tell you where pressure is building. Cracks tell you what's unsustainable. And if you're wise, you'll check your own walls before you point at someone else's.

Chapter 9

Steady Hands

The second attack came three weeks after the first.

This time, they were ready.

The western coops had been reinforced with lumber donated at cost by suppliers who remembered how Eggerton paid its bills. Night watches rotated in shifts, armed with lanterns and cowbells and the particular alertness of people protecting something they loved. When the foxes came—four of them this time, slipping through the darkness with that same unnatural boldness—they were met not with sleeping birds but with shouting workers, clanging metal, and a coordinated response that sent them fleeing before a single hen was touched.

"They tried," the night watch captain reported at dawn, his voice hoarse but triumphant. "Cut the same kind of hole in the fence. Professional job. But we were waiting."

Lady De examined the cut fence in the morning light. Clean edges. Deliberate placement. No wild animal made cuts like these.

"Crestfall," she said quietly.

"Can we prove it?" Garrick asked.

"No. And it doesn't matter." She straightened, turning to face the gathered workers. "What matters is that we held. We prepared, we watched, and we held."

A cheer went up—ragged, tired, but genuine. The workers had defended their birds. They had taken something that had been done to them and refused to let it be done again.

That was victory. Small, unglamorous, but real.

* * *

The monthly egg-coloring contest fell on the following Saturday, and the court debated whether to proceed.

"We're stretched thin," Garrick argued. "Resources, attention, energy—everything is going to defense and rebuilding. Is this really the time for children's games?"

"It's exactly the time," the Herald of Honest Eggs [MARKETING] countered. "The market needs to see us continuing. Not just surviving—thriving. If we cancel

the contest, we tell everyone that Crestfall's attacks are working. That we're scared. That we're retreating."

"Are we not scared?" Beatrice the Patient [ACCOUNTS PAYABLE] asked quietly. "I am. A little."

The honesty hung in the air. Beatrice rarely admitted weakness—her role demanded steadiness, the calm orchestration of outgoing payments regardless of circumstance. For her to acknowledge fear meant something.

"We're all scared," Lady De said. "That's not shameful. Fear is just information—it tells you something matters enough to lose. The question is what we do with the fear."

"What do you want to do?" the King asked.

Lady De was quiet for a moment, turning the egg in her pocket, feeling its weight.

"I want to hold the contest," she said finally. "But I want to do it differently. I want to dedicate it to the birds we lost."

The court stirred. Pip's quill paused over his journal.

"Explain," Queen Verity said.

"The Brigadier. The seventeen hens. They were part of Eggerton—not just assets on a ledger, but members of what we're building here. We mourned them, and that was right. But mourning isn't the same as remembering." Lady De looked around the room. "I want the children to paint eggs in their memory. I want to tell their stories—which hen laid double-yolks, which one escaped constantly, which one hated the color blue. I want to make the loss part of the celebration, not separate from it."

"Joy and grief together," Lady Continuance [STATEMENT OF EQUITY] said slowly. "That's very... Eggerton."

"It's very human," Lady De corrected. "We don't stop living because we've lost. We carry the lost with us into the living."

The vote was unanimous. The contest would proceed.

* * *

Saturday arrived bright and clear, as if the weather itself had decided to cooperate.

The contest tables were set up in the usual spot, dyes arranged in rainbow order, eggs distributed to eager hands. But this time, there was something new: a

small memorial board near the entrance, listing the names of the birds lost in the attack, with brief descriptions of their personalities and quirks.

BRIGADIER, the board read. Proud. Protective. Would fight his own reflection if he thought it was looking at his hens wrong.

LADY MARMALADE. Best layer in the eastern coop. Once escaped seven times in one week. We still don't know how.

DUCHESS WOBBLES. Named by a child visitor who thought she walked funny. She did. We loved her anyway.

Children gathered around the board, reading the names aloud, asking their parents questions. "Why did the foxes come?" "Will they come again?" "Did the chickens know they were going to die?"

Parents answered as best they could—honestly, gently, without false comfort or unnecessary fear. This was part of life. Sometimes bad things happened. The important thing was how you responded.

And then the children painted.

They painted eggs in honor of Brigadier, bold and red and fierce. They painted eggs for Lady Marmalade,

covered in tiny door shapes to represent her escapes. They painted eggs for Duchess Wobbles, deliberately wobbly, imperfectly perfect.

The refugee children painted too—the weaver's daughters, the blacksmith's son, others who had arrived in the weeks since the first families fled Crestfall. They didn't know the lost birds, but they understood loss. They painted eggs in colors that meant something to them: homes left behind, gardens that had stopped growing, parents who tried to hide their fear but couldn't quite manage it.

By afternoon, the contest tables were covered with eggs that told stories. Grief and joy, memory and hope, all mixed together in pigment and shell.

Lady De walked among the tables, stopping to admire each creation, asking children about their choices, listening to the stories they were learning to tell. This was what Eggerton was. Not just a kingdom that sold eggs, but a community that knew how to hold things together when they wanted to fall apart.

"Lady De!" A small voice called out—the weaver's youngest daughter, the one who had stared at the omelet pan with such reverence on her first day. She held up an egg, painted in swirls of brown and gold. "I made this for you!"

Lady De knelt to receive it. The egg was clumsy, the colors muddy in places where they'd mixed too much, the swirls more chaotic than artistic. It was beautiful.

"What does it represent?" she asked.

"The egg you gave me," the girl said. "When I was hungry. I wanted to remember it."

Lady De's throat tightened. She'd given away hundreds of eggs in her years as Steward—thousands, probably. Most she didn't remember. But this girl had remembered. This girl had turned a simple act of feeding into something worth commemorating.

"I'll keep it forever," Lady De said, and meant it.

* * *

The Moneylender Lord arrived on Monday.

He was not what most people expected from someone who controlled purse strings and demanded repayment schedules. He was small, soft-spoken, with kind eyes and a habit of nodding thoughtfully at everything that was said to him. He looked like someone's favorite grandfather, which made him extremely effective at his job.

"Lady Hearthstone," he said, settling into the chair Lady De had arranged for him in the counting hall. "I've reviewed your proposal. It's thorough."

"We believe in knowing our numbers," Lady De replied.

"So I see." He opened the leather folder containing the Prophet's projections, the Oracles' ratio analysis, Magnus's verified accounts. "Debt-to-equity at 0.6 post-loan. Interest coverage at three-to-one. Projected repayment timeline of eighteen months with comfortable margin for variance." He looked up. "These are not the numbers of a desperate kingdom."

"We're not desperate. We're damaged. There's a difference."

"Is there?"

"Desperate kingdoms make decisions from fear. They overpromise, underdeliver, and collapse when the first unexpected cost arrives." Lady De met his gaze steadily. "We've been attacked. We've lost birds. We've had to restructure our entire security approach. And through all of it, we've kept our initiatives running, maintained our market presence, and welcomed refugees from a kingdom that's trying to destroy us. That's not desperation. That's resilience."

The Moneylender Lord [DEBT] nodded slowly, that characteristic thoughtful gesture. "And if Crestfall attacks again? If your losses increase beyond these projections?"

"Then we adjust. We have contingency scenarios built into every forecast. We know our floor—the minimum position below which we will not fall regardless of circumstance. And we know our ceiling—the maximum debt we can responsibly service even in adverse conditions." Lady De gestured to the documents spread before him. "It's all there. We're not asking you to trust us blindly. We're asking you to trust the math."

"The math is good," the Moneylender Lord admitted. "But math is only part of lending. The other part is character."

"Then judge our character by our actions. We pay our suppliers fairly and on time—ask them. We honor our commitments even when it costs us—ask anyone who's done business with Eggerton. We welcome enemies as workers and feed hungry children before asking where they came from." Lady De paused. "Is that the character you're looking for?"

The Moneylender Lord was quiet for a long moment. Then he smiled—a small, genuine expression that transformed his grandfatherly face.

"I'll approve the loan," he said. "Standard terms, competitive rates. You'll have the funds within the week."

"Thank you."

"Don't thank me. You did the work. I just agreed with your conclusions." He stood, gathering his documents. "One piece of advice, Lady Hearthstone, from someone who's seen many kingdoms borrow and many kingdoms fail: the loan isn't what saves you or destroys you. What you do with it is. Use it wisely."

"We intend to."

"I believe you do." He paused at the door. "I hear your egg-coloring contest was quite moving. My granddaughter attended. She painted an egg for a chicken named Duchess Wobbles."

Lady De smiled. "Duchess Wobbles was special. She walked funny."

"So I'm told." The Moneylender Lord nodded once more, then departed.

Lady De sat alone in the counting hall, the approved loan documents before her, the weight of borrowed money settling onto her shoulders. It was a good weight, she decided. The weight of opportunity. The weight of a future they could now afford to build.

She reached into her pocket and pulled out the egg the weaver's daughter had painted for her—swirls of brown and gold, clumsy and beautiful.

This was what they were protecting. This was what the loan would help them keep.

Not just eggs. Not just chickens. But the ability to feed hungry children and remember what mattered and hold contests in the middle of crises because joy wasn't a luxury—it was a necessity.

* * *

That evening, the court gathered to receive the news.

"The loan is approved," Lady De announced. "Funds arrive within the week. We begin rebuilding immediately."

Applause broke out—restrained, professional, but genuine. They had done it. They had faced attack and loss and the prospect of debt, and they had emerged

with their position strengthened rather than weakened.

"New birds ordered," the Warehouse Master reported. "Fifty layers, premium stock. They'll arrive in ten days."

"Security upgrades scheduled," added the head of the night watch. "Every coop reinforced within the month."

"And our debt service begins next quarter," Garrick noted, because someone had to keep track of the obligations. "We'll need to maintain revenue at current levels minimum."

"We will," Lady De said. "The initiatives are working. The refugees are integrating. And Crestfall..." She paused. "Crestfall is falling. Not because of anything we did to them—because of what they did to themselves."

"Do we celebrate that?" Pip asked quietly. It was an honest question, the kind he was known for. "Their failure?"

Lady De considered it. "No. We don't celebrate anyone's failure. But we also don't pretend it isn't happening. Crestfall made choices. Those choices have consequences. Our job isn't to gloat—our job is

to be ready for whatever those consequences bring to our door."

"More refugees," Queen Verity predicted.

"Almost certainly. And eventually, maybe, something larger." Lady De looked around the table at the court that had become her family, the kingdom that had become her purpose. "Whatever comes, we face it the same way we've faced everything else. With steady hands and open books and eggs in our pockets."

She produced the painted egg—the weaver's daughter's gift—and set it on the table beside the loan documents.

"This is what we're building," she said. "A kingdom where hungry children get fed. Where lost birds get remembered. Where the numbers add up because we make sure they do, every single day." She smiled. "Not glamorous. Not dramatic. But real. And ours."

The court raised their cups—water, mostly, with a few glasses of something stronger—and drank to steady hands.

Outside, the sun was setting over Eggerton. Somewhere, new chickens were being prepared for transport. Somewhere, refugees were settling into new homes. Somewhere, Crestfall was crumbling.

And here, in the counting hall, the Court of Accounts was doing what it did best: counting what they had, planning what came next, and trusting that the steady work would be enough.

It usually was. It had to be.

* * *

Sidebar Note from Kari: Steady hands don't mean unshaking hands. They mean hands that keep working even when they want to shake. That's the difference between composure and numbness. You feel everything—the fear, the grief, the uncertainty—and you keep counting anyway. That's not suppression. That's discipline. And discipline, done right, is its own kind of love.

Chapter 10

The Chicken Fashion Show (Encore)

The quarterly fashion show was announced three weeks in advance, and the seamstress guild took it as a personal challenge.

"We're going bigger," the head seamstress declared at their planning meeting, surrounded by fabric swatches and sketches and the particular intensity of craftspeople who had been given permission to be ridiculous. "Last time was proof of concept. This time is art."

Lady De had approved the budget—modest, as always, but supplemented by donations from merchants who understood that spectacle sold eggs. The refugees had brought unexpected skills: the weaver's family contributed fabric remnants in colors Eggerton had never seen, while a tailor from Crestfall (fled three weeks prior, still jumpy around loud noises) offered to construct miniature military uniforms "because if chickens are going to march, they should march properly."

The event was scheduled for the first Saturday of autumn, when the leaves were just beginning to turn

and the air had that particular crispness that made people want to gather outdoors and witness something wonderful.

What no one expected was the stranger who arrived the day before.

* * *

Silas the Ledgerkeeper [CRESTFALL'S GENERAL LEDGER] crossed the border at dawn, carrying nothing but a leather satchel and the weight of three generations of service to a kingdom that no longer deserved it.

He had not planned to leave on that particular morning. He had not planned to leave at all, really—the decision had crept up on him slowly, like the failure of Crestfall's crops, until suddenly it was undeniable. He woke before sunrise, looked at the hidden journal beneath his floorboard, and knew with absolute certainty that he could not write another entry about disaster while doing nothing to stop it.

So he packed the journal. And he walked east.

The border between Crestfall and Eggerton was unmarked—no walls, no guards, just a gentle rise of hills and then a descent into greener fields. Silas had

expected to feel something when he crossed: guilt, perhaps, or fear, or the sharp pain of betrayal. Instead, he felt only exhaustion, and beneath it, something that might have been relief.

He arrived at Eggerton's market by midmorning, footsore and hungry and entirely uncertain what to do next. The market was busier than Crestfall's had been in months—vendors calling out prices, customers haggling cheerfully, the smell of food and commerce and life filling the air.

And everywhere, signs for something called "The Quarterly Chicken Fashion Show."

Silas stared at the nearest poster, certain he had misread. He had not.

CHICKENS. IN COSTUMES. PRIZES FOR BEST DRESSED.

He stood there for a long moment, the satchel heavy on his shoulder, trying to reconcile this absurdity with everything he thought he knew about kingdoms and commerce and survival. Crestfall was starving. Crestfall was poisoning its own soil. Crestfall was bleeding workers and coin and hope. And Eggerton was... dressing up chickens?

"First time seeing the posters?"

Silas turned. A young woman stood nearby—plain clothes, kind eyes, an egg-shaped pin on her collar that seemed to indicate some official capacity.

"Is it real?" he asked, gesturing at the poster.

"Very real. Tomorrow afternoon. You should come." She tilted her head, studying him. "You're new here."

"I'm—" He hesitated. What was he? A refugee? A defector? A traitor? "I'm from the west."

"Crestfall." Not a question. "We've had a few of those lately. Are you hungry?"

Silas realized, with some surprise, that he was. He'd been too anxious to eat before leaving, and the walk had taken longer than expected.

"There's an omelet station," the woman said, pointing. "Tell them Clara sent you. They'll feed you, no questions asked." She paused. "Questions can come later, if you want. For now, just eat."

Silas found himself walking toward the smell of cooking eggs before he'd consciously decided to move. Behind him, Clara watched with the particular satisfaction of someone who had learned that kindness was its own kind of strategy.

* * *

The fashion show began at two o'clock, and by one-thirty, the market square was packed.

Silas had spent the morning wandering, observing, taking mental notes out of professional habit. The market was well-organized—stalls arranged for optimal foot traffic, prices clearly displayed, workers who seemed genuinely happy rather than merely compliant. The refugees he spotted (he could recognize them now, that particular mix of relief and lingering fear) moved through the crowds freely, some already working stalls, others still finding their footing.

No one asked where he was from. No one demanded papers or explanations or loyalty oaths. He was simply... present. Allowed. Accepted, at least provisionally, into the flow of commerce and community.

It was disorienting. It was wonderful.

By early afternoon, he had secured a spot near the front of the runway—a raised wooden platform draped in colorful fabric, with a small stage at one end where someone was testing a hand-cranked music box. Children jostled for position. Parents hoisted

toddlers onto shoulders. Vendors circulated with snacks and drinks, doing brisk business.

And then the music began, and the chickens emerged, and Silas the Ledgerkeeper—serious keeper of serious records, meticulous documentarian of fiscal disaster—felt something crack open in his chest.

The first chicken wore a ballgown.

An actual ballgown, scaled down to poultry proportions, with a full skirt of emerald silk and tiny pearls sewn along the neckline. The hen who wore it processed down the runway with the absolute dignity of someone who knew she was magnificent, pausing at intervals to allow the crowd to appreciate her splendor.

The crowd went wild. Cheering, applauding, laughing with pure delight.

Silas felt his mouth twitch. Then curve. Then—impossibly—stretch into something he barely recognized.

He was smiling. Actually smiling. When had he last smiled?

The second chicken wore a knight's armor, fashioned from painted leather and tiny metal rivets. It clanked

slightly as the rooster strutted, clearly convinced that he was indeed a warrior of great renown.

The third chicken wore what could only be described as "baroque nightmare with feathers"—layers upon layers of ruffles and ribbons and inexplicable flourishes that defied both gravity and good taste. The crowd loved it.

By the fourth chicken—a hen in a tiny crown and ermine-trimmed cape, processing with the dignity of actual royalty—Silas was laughing. Not chuckling. Not the polite, restrained amusement he had permitted himself in council meetings. Actually laughing, the sound rough from disuse, tears forming at the corners of his eyes.

Around him, everyone else was laughing too. Children, parents, workers, merchants, refugees. Enemies and strangers and newcomers, all united in the shared absurdity of watching chickens in formal wear parade down a runway.

This was what Crestfall was fighting against? This was what Michlen wanted to destroy?

Joy. Pure, ridiculous, ungovernable joy.

Silas thought about all the ledgers he'd kept, all the numbers he'd recorded, all the careful documentation

of Crestfall's slow collapse. None of it had captured this. None of it could. You couldn't quantify laughter. You couldn't put delight on a balance sheet. But it was real—as real as any asset, as valuable as any inventory.

And Michlen, in all his calculations about market share and pricing strategies and competitive advantage, had never once accounted for it.

That, Silas realized, was why Crestfall was losing. Not because Eggerton had better eggs or lower costs or smarter workers. Because Eggerton had this. This capacity for joy. This willingness to be absurd in service of connection. This understanding that a kingdom wasn't just an economy—it was a community, and communities needed to laugh together as much as they needed to trade.

The fashion show continued. More chickens, more costumes, more escalating ridiculousness. A chicken in a tiny chef's hat. A chicken dressed as a sunflower. A chicken in formal judicial robes, looking deeply unimpressed by the proceedings.

And Silas laughed at all of them, the sound mixing with hundreds of other laughs, becoming part of something larger than himself.

He had made the right choice. He knew that now, with a certainty that went deeper than any ledger entry.

He was home.

* * *

Lady De spotted him near the end of the show—the man in the worn traveling clothes, laughing harder than anyone else in the crowd. She didn't recognize him, but she recognized the type: refugee, recent arrival, experiencing Eggerton's particular magic for the first time.

She made her way through the crowd as the final chicken took its bow (a hen in an elaborate wedding dress, veil trailing behind her like a feathered bride). The stranger was wiping his eyes, still grinning, looking slightly dazed.

"Good show?" she asked.

He turned. "I've never seen anything like it."

"That's rather the point." She extended her hand. "Lady De. I help run things around here."

His expression shifted—recognition, followed by something more complicated. Wariness? Respect? Fear?

"I know who you are," he said slowly. "I've read about you. In... reports."

"Reports?" Lady De's eyes sharpened. "What kind of reports?"

The man reached into his satchel and withdrew a leather-bound journal, worn with use and thick with pages.

"My name is Silas," he said. "I was the Ledgerkeeper of Crestfall. I kept records of everything—including the attacks on your kingdom, the strategies to destroy your market, and the systematic collapse of my own." He held out the journal. "And I'd very much like to show you what I've seen."

Lady De looked at the journal. Looked at the man—exhausted, earnest, still bearing traces of laughter from the show.

"You're the one who kept Michlen's books."

"I kept records Michlen refused to read. There's a difference." Silas's voice was steady now, the dazed joy settling into something more grounded. "I documented every decision he made and every consequence that followed. The fox attacks. The poisoned soil. The treasury depletion. It's all here—dates, figures, outcomes. Everything."

"Why bring it to us?"

"Because someone should see it. Because the truth should exist somewhere outside my hidden floorboard. And because—" He gestured at the dispersing crowd, the colorful runway, the chickens being carefully de-costumed by their handlers. "Because I watched that show, and I laughed, and I realized that everything Michlen was trying to destroy was worth more than everything he was trying to build."

Lady De was quiet for a long moment. Around them, the market was returning to normal—vendors packing up, families heading home, workers already beginning to clean the square.

"Come with me," she said finally. "There's someone you should meet."

* * *

Magnus Vaultwell [THE GENERAL LEDGER] looked up from his accounts as Lady De entered the counting hall with a stranger. His eyebrows rose when he saw the leather journal in the man's hands—one ledgerkeeper always recognized another's tools.

"Magnus, this is Silas. He was Crestfall's ledgerkeeper. He's brought us... documentation."

Magnus set down his quill with the careful precision of a man who never made sudden movements near important papers. "What kind of documentation?"

"Everything," Silas said. "Every order Michlen gave. Every strategy he implemented. Every cost, every loss, every consequence he refused to acknowledge." He set the journal on Magnus's desk. "I couldn't stop any of it. But I could write it down. So I did."

Magnus opened the journal, scanning the first few pages. His expression didn't change—it never did—but his fingers paused over certain entries, lingering on figures that told stories of their own.

"This is... comprehensive," he said finally.

"I'm a ledgerkeeper. Comprehensive is what we do."

For a moment, the two men regarded each other—different kingdoms, different loyalties, but the same fundamental commitment to truth in numbers. Something passed between them. Recognition. Respect.

"Welcome to Eggerton," Magnus said. "We could use another set of careful hands."

Lady De smiled. "Before we discuss employment, there's a more immediate question." She turned to Silas. "Have you eaten properly since you arrived? And I don't mean just omelets."

Silas hesitated. "I... not really. I was too—"

"Overwhelmed. I know." She moved toward the door. "Come. We'll find you a proper meal, a proper bed, and tomorrow—tomorrow we'll talk about what's in that journal and what it means for what's coming."

"What is coming?"

Lady De paused at the threshold, looking back at the man who had crossed a border and brought his kingdom's secrets with him.

"The end of Crestfall, I think. One way or another." Her voice was matter-of-fact, neither gloating nor grieving. "And we need to be ready for it."

Silas followed her out into the evening air, where the market square was now quiet and the smell of cooked omelets still lingered. Somewhere, chickens were being returned to their coops, divested of finery, settling in for the night.

He had laughed today. Really laughed, for the first time in years.

He had defected from everything he'd known.

He had met two ledgerkeepers—one who kept the books of a thriving kingdom, one who carried eggs in her pockets and welcomed enemies with meals.

And tomorrow, he would help them understand exactly how bad things had become in the kingdom he'd left behind.

It was terrifying. It was right.

The numbers would finally be read by someone willing to act on them.

* * *

Sidebar Note from Kari: Sometimes the thing that breaks you open isn't tragedy. It's joy. Sometimes you don't realize how tight you've been holding everything until you laugh so hard you cry and suddenly all that tightness just... lets go. Don't underestimate absurdity. It's a door. And sometimes it's the only door left.

Chapter 11

The Ledgerkeeper's Choice

The court convened at dawn the next morning, every seat filled, every eye on the stranger who had brought Crestfall's secrets across the border in a leather satchel.

Silas stood at the head of the table—the place usually reserved for those giving formal reports—with his journal open before him. He had not slept well; the bed had been comfortable enough, but his mind had refused to quiet, running through figures and dates and the weight of what he was about to share.

"Before I begin," he said, his voice steadier than he felt, "I want to be clear about what this is. This journal is not a weapon. It's not revenge. It's not an attempt to justify my decision to leave." He looked around the room, meeting the eyes of people who had every reason to distrust him. "It's simply the truth. Numbers don't lie, and these numbers tell a story that Michlen refused to hear. I'm hoping you'll listen better than he did."

"We're listening," Lady De said.

Silas nodded and began.

* * *

The presentation took nearly two hours.

He walked them through Crestfall's finances quarter by quarter, showing how the aggressive pricing strategy had bled the treasury dry. He documented the fox attacks—dates, costs, the explicit orders from Michlen that proved they were sabotage rather than natural predation. He laid out the soil poisoning in devastating detail: which fields, which chemicals, what the projected recovery timeline looked like (years, not months), and how many families had already fled rather than eat what the ruined land produced.

The Oracles [FINANCIAL RATIOS] studied his figures with the particular intensity of people encountering a kindred spirit's work. The Prophet [CASH FLOW FORECAST] asked clarifying questions about methodology, nodding approvingly at his answers. Magnus Vaultwell [THE GENERAL LEDGER] followed along in silence, occasionally making notes in his own ledger—cross-references, perhaps, or simply the habit of documentation.

When Silas finished, the room was quiet.

"This is worse than we thought," Queen Verity [THE BALANCE SHEET] said finally. "Far worse."

"Crestfall isn't just struggling," Silas confirmed. "It's collapsing. The treasury is at eleven percent of last year's position. The productive farmland is down by a third, with no recovery in sight. Skilled workers are fleeing faster than they can be replaced." He paused. "And Michlen's response to all of this has been to order more attacks on Eggerton, as if destroying your kingdom could somehow save his own."

"Can it?" Garrick at the Gate [CASH FLOW] asked.

"No." Silas's voice was flat, certain. "The math doesn't work. It never worked. I tried to show him—" He stopped, swallowed. "I tried to show him dozens of times. He wouldn't look at the numbers."

"Why not?" the King asked quietly.

"Because the numbers told him things he didn't want to hear. That his strategy was failing. That his father's approach—steady, careful, boring—had actually been working. That you can't shortcut your way to prosperity." Silas shook his head. "He wanted to believe that destruction was the same as creation. That tearing down Eggerton would somehow build up

Crestfall. And no amount of evidence could convince him otherwise."

* * *

The questions continued for another hour—detailed inquiries about specific entries, requests for clarification on timelines, cross-examinations that tested the reliability of Silas's record-keeping. Through it all, he answered patiently, thoroughly, with the precision of someone who had spent his entire career making sure numbers added up correctly.

Finally, Lord Pemberton's name came up.

"He's still in Crestfall?" Lady De asked.

"As of when I left, yes. He and Lady Ashworth were the only council members still willing to question Michlen openly. The rest have either fled or learned to stay silent."

"And what do they say? Pemberton and Ashworth?"

Silas hesitated. This was delicate—the words of people who hadn't chosen to defect, whose positions he might be compromising by repeating their doubts.

"They say what I wrote in the ledger," he said carefully. "That the strategy is unsustainable. That the cost of

attacking Eggerton exceeds any possible benefit. That the kingdom is being sacrificed for one man's pride."

"But they stay."

"They have families. Estates. Generations of roots." Silas's voice softened. "Leaving isn't simple. I had nothing holding me except duty, and even that took months to release."

Sir Ludo Quarterly [PROFIT & LOSS] leaned forward. "Here's what I don't understand. You say the numbers are clear. You say anyone who looks at them can see Crestfall is failing. But Michlen has advisors, analysts, people whose job is to interpret financial data. How could they all miss this?"

"They didn't miss it," Silas said. "They reported it. Repeatedly. In every format imaginable—summaries, charts, projections, scenarios. They laid out the numbers as clearly as I'm laying them out for you now."

"And?"

"And Michlen would push the reports aside." Silas's jaw tightened at the memory. "He'd say the numbers could be interpreted different ways. That different analysts would reach different conclusions. That the

figures didn't account for intangibles like market psychology or competitive momentum."

"He dismissed the math," Magnus said slowly, "by claiming math was subjective?"

"Essentially, yes."

The room stirred. Even among people who had seen many kinds of foolishness, this particular flavor was remarkable.

Lady De had been quiet for several minutes, turning an egg over in her hands—her constant companion, her thinking tool. Now she set it down on the table with a soft click.

"I've met people like that," she said. "People who think that because humans do the counting, the count itself is somehow negotiable. That numbers are just opinions dressed up in arithmetic." Her voice was calm, but there was iron underneath. "You know what I tell those people?"

Silas shook his head.

Lady De looked around the room—at the Oracles with their ratio analyses, at Magnus with his meticulous ledgers, at the Prophet with her forecasts, at all the

people who had built their lives around the discipline of accurate counting.

"I tell them: See, that's the nice thing about math. There is only one right answer."

The words landed in the silence like a stone in still water.

Silas stared at her. In all his years of trying to convince Michlen, of presenting evidence that was dismissed and projections that were ignored and warnings that went unheeded, he had never found the words to capture what was so fundamentally wrong about the king's thinking.

But Lady De had just done it. In one sentence.

"Yes," he said, his voice rough. "That's exactly it. That's exactly what he never understood."

"Then he was never going to save Crestfall," Queen Verity said. "You can't run a kingdom if you don't believe in the numbers that tell you how it's running."

"No," Silas agreed. "You can't."

* * *

The court took a brief recess—time to absorb what they'd heard, to stretch legs and refill cups and process the scope of Crestfall's collapse. Silas found himself standing alone by the window, looking out at Eggerton's market square, watching merchants set up their stalls for another day of commerce.

Lady De joined him.

"You did well in there," she said.

"I reported numbers. That's what I do."

"You did more than that. You made a choice. You left everything you knew because the truth mattered more than comfort." She stood beside him, watching the same view. "That's not nothing."

Silas was quiet for a moment. "When I watched the fashion show yesterday, I thought about all the entries in my journal. All the documentation of attacks and strategies and costs. And I realized that none of it captured what Eggerton actually is." He gestured at the window. "This. People setting up stalls because they believe there will be customers. Children running through the square because they feel safe. Chickens in ballgowns because someone decided joy was worth the effort."

"The intangibles," Lady De said.

"Yes. The things Michlen claimed his numbers couldn't account for." Silas shook his head. "But that was backwards. His numbers couldn't account for them because he never tried to build them. He was so focused on destroying what you had that he never thought about creating something worth keeping."

"And now?"

"Now I'd like to help you keep it. If you'll have me."

Lady De was quiet for a long moment. Then she reached into her pocket and produced an egg—not the one from the table, but a different one, painted in swirls of brown and gold.

"The weaver's daughter made this for me," she said. "The day after she arrived, hungry and scared and not sure if she'd made the right choice leaving Crestfall. I gave her an omelet, and she painted me an egg to remember it by."

She pressed it into his hands.

"Welcome to Eggerton, Silas. We don't have a lot of rules here, but we have one that matters: you count what you have, you protect what you count, and you never stop looking for ways to build more than you started with."

Silas looked at the painted egg—clumsy, beautiful, a child's gift to a stranger who had fed her.

"I can work with that," he said.

* * *

When the court reconvened, the discussion shifted from what had happened to what would happen next.

"Crestfall is going to fall," Lady De said bluntly. "The numbers Silas has shown us make that clear. The question is what happens after—and what our role should be."

"Do we have a role?" Garrick asked. "They've been attacking us. They've tried to destroy us. Why would we help them?"

"Because they're not all Michlen," Lady De said. "The people—the workers, the farmers, the families—they didn't choose this war. They're the ones suffering for it. And when Crestfall collapses completely, they'll need somewhere to go."

"More refugees," Queen Verity observed.

"Many more. Potentially the entire kingdom's population, if things get bad enough." Lady De looked around the table. "We need to be ready. Not just to

accept them, but to absorb them. To integrate an entire kingdom's worth of people into our own."

"Can we afford that?" Sir Ludo asked.

"Can we afford not to?" Lady De countered. "Those people have skills—farming, crafting, trading. They have knowledge of Crestfall's land, which will eventually recover and could become productive again. They have children who could grow up as Eggerton's citizens, contributing to our future." She paused. "And they have something else: they've seen what happens when a kingdom ignores its numbers. That lesson is worth more than gold."

The Prophet [CASH FLOW FORECAST] had been running calculations throughout the discussion. Now she looked up.

"If we're talking about absorbing Crestfall's population—even gradually—we're looking at significant capital requirements. Housing, food, integration support, expanded infrastructure." She consulted her figures. "Our current loan covers the chicken replacement and security upgrades. This would require... considerably more."

"How much more?"

"Potentially triple our current debt position. Maybe more, depending on how fast the collapse happens."

The room fell silent. Triple the debt. It was a staggering number—the kind of commitment that could break a kingdom if things went wrong.

"The Moneylender Lord," the King said slowly.

"Would need to see a very compelling proposal," the Prophet agreed. "But it's not impossible. Our fundamentals are strong. Our repayment history is solid. And this isn't speculative expansion—it's humanitarian necessity combined with strategic opportunity."

"You're talking about buying a kingdom," Garrick said.

"I'm talking about saving one," Lady De corrected. "There's a difference."

She looked at Silas, who had been listening quietly from his seat near Magnus.

"You know Crestfall better than anyone here. If we do this—if we prepare to absorb your former kingdom—what do we need to know?"

Silas considered the question. It was strange, being asked to help plan the absorption of the place he'd served his entire life. Strange, but not wrong. Crestfall

as it existed under Michlen wasn't worth saving. But the land, the people, the possibility of something better—that was worth everything.

"You need to know that the transition will be messy," he said. "People will grieve what they've lost, even if what they lost was hurting them. You need to be patient with that grief." He paused. "And you need to know that Michlen won't go quietly. Even as everything falls apart around him, he'll keep believing he can win. He'll keep attacking. He'll keep making things worse."

"Then we prepare for that too," Lady De said. "We strengthen our defenses. We document everything. And when the time comes, we're ready to catch what falls."

She picked up the egg from the table—her constant companion, her reminder of what all the counting was for.

"We're not conquerors. We're not vultures. We're a kingdom that counts its eggs and takes care of what it has." She looked around at the court. "And sometimes taking care of what you have means making room for more."

* * *

That evening, Silas sat in his new quarters—a small room in the castle's guest wing, modest but clean—and began a new journal.

Not a record of disaster this time. A record of rebuilding.

He wrote about the court meeting, the questions asked, the decisions contemplated. He wrote about Lady De's line—"the nice thing about math is there is only one right answer"—and how it had crystallized something he'd been trying to articulate for years.

And he wrote about the painted egg she'd given him, now sitting on his desk, a gift from a child who'd been hungry and was now fed.

Day one in Eggerton. The court received my documentation without suspicion or contempt. They asked questions designed to understand, not to dismiss. When I presented numbers, they engaged with them—challenged them, verified them, built upon them. This is what Crestfall could have been. This is what any kingdom could be, if its leaders were willing to count honestly and act on what they found.

He set down his quill and looked out the window at Eggerton settling into evening. Somewhere, chickens were roosting in reinforced coops. Somewhere,

refugees were eating meals they hadn't had to grow in poisoned soil. Somewhere, a little girl with painted eggs was sleeping safely.

The numbers had finally found someone willing to read them.

And Silas, for the first time in years, felt like his work actually mattered.

* * *

Sidebar Note from Kari: There IS only one right answer. People who tell you math is subjective are usually people who don't like what the math is telling them. Numbers don't have opinions. Numbers don't play favorites. Numbers just... are. And the people who understand that—who respect that—are the ones who can actually build something that lasts.

—

Chapter 12

When Crestfall Falls

The end came on a Wednesday, though it had been arriving for months.

Silas heard the news from a merchant who crossed the border at dawn, breathless and wide-eyed, carrying nothing but the clothes on his back and a story that had already begun to feel like legend.

"The castle is empty," the merchant said, accepting the cup of water someone pressed into his shaking hands. "Michlen left in the night. Took what gold remained in the treasury—not much, from what I heard—and rode south toward the coast. They say he's looking for a ship."

"And the people?" Lady De asked. She had been summoned from her morning market walk the moment the merchant arrived, and now stood in the counting hall with the court assembling around her.

"Confused. Scared. Some are already walking east—toward here. Others are trying to salvage what they can from their farms, their shops." The merchant's

voice cracked. "There's no one in charge. No one telling anyone what to do. It's just... chaos."

Lady De turned to the court. Every face showed the same mix of emotions: vindication, concern, determination, and beneath it all, the particular weight of a moment they'd prepared for but hoped might never come.

"It's time," she said simply.

* * *

The plan had been refined over weeks of careful discussion, adjusted as new refugees brought fresh intelligence, stress-tested by the Oracles and the Prophet until every contingency had a contingency.

Phase one: immediate humanitarian response. Wagons loaded with food and basic supplies, dispatched to the border crossing points where refugees would gather. The Herald of Honest Eggs [MARKETING] would accompany them, his voice carrying messages of welcome and reassurance to people who had been taught to see Eggerton as an enemy.

"You are not invaders," Lady De had written in the proclamation he would read. "You are not prisoners.

You are not conquered. You are people in need, and Eggerton does not turn away people in need. Come. Eat. Rest. We will figure out the rest together."

Phase two: assessment and integration. As refugees arrived, they would be registered—not to track or control them, but to understand their skills, their needs, their family situations. The weaver's family had taught Eggerton something valuable: refugees weren't just mouths to feed, they were hands that could work, minds that could contribute, lives that could enrich the kingdom if given the chance.

"We need carpenters," the master builder had noted during planning. "And farmers who understand soil recovery. And anyone with medical training—we're going to see illness from the poisoned crops, mark my words."

Phase three: property assessment. This was the delicate part—the part that required Silas's knowledge most acutely. Crestfall's lands, its buildings, its infrastructure, all now sat ownerless. Someone would need to claim them, manage them, rehabilitate them. The question was whether Eggerton could afford to be that someone.

"The Moneylender Lord has approved the expanded loan," the Prophet [CASH FLOW FORECAST] reported.

"Terms are favorable—he believes in what we're doing. But we'll be leveraged significantly. More than we've ever been."

"More than Crestfall was?" Garrick asked.

"No." The Prophet's voice was firm. "Not even close. Michlen borrowed against fantasy—projected revenues that could never materialize, growth that required destroying someone else. We're borrowing against reality—documented assets, proven revenue streams, and a workforce that's about to triple."

"The numbers work," Magnus Vaultwell [THE GENERAL LEDGER] confirmed. He had been reviewing the projections for days, looking for weaknesses, finding none that weren't already accounted for. "They're aggressive, but they work."

Lady De nodded. "Then we proceed."

* * *

The refugees began arriving before noon.

First in trickles—families who had been packed and ready, waiting for an excuse to leave. Then in streams—workers who had nothing left to work with, farmers whose fields produced only poison,

merchants whose stalls had stood empty for weeks. By evening, the stream had become a river.

Eggerton's market square transformed into a processing center, orderly despite the volume. Tables were set up for registration. The omelet station ran continuously, feeding people who hadn't eaten properly in days. Children were gathered into groups, supervised by volunteers who kept them occupied with games and stories while their parents navigated the chaos of starting over.

Lady De moved through it all, an egg in her pocket as always, stopping to speak with families, to answer questions, to simply be present. Leadership, she had learned, wasn't always about making decisions. Sometimes it was just about showing up.

"Lady Hearthstone?" A woman's voice, hesitant but determined.

Lady De turned. The woman was middle-aged, well-dressed despite the dust of travel, with the bearing of someone accustomed to being listened to. Beside her stood an older man with a nobleman's posture and a politician's careful expression.

"Lady Ashworth," Silas said, appearing at Lady De's elbow. "And Lord Pemberton. They were on Michlen's council."

The two nobles exchanged glances—the particular look of people who had been caught and weren't sure yet whether that was good or bad.

"We stayed as long as we could," Lady Ashworth said quietly. "Tried to moderate his worst impulses. It... didn't work."

"Why come now?" Lady De asked. Not accusatory—genuinely curious.

"Because there's nothing left to stay for," Lord Pemberton answered. "And because Silas is here. When we heard he'd defected, we knew..." He trailed off, searching for words.

"You knew the numbers had finally found someone who would read them," Lady De finished.

"Yes." Pemberton's shoulders sagged slightly—relief, perhaps, or just the exhaustion of carrying impossible weight for too long. "We have information. About Michlen's final orders, about what's left of the treasury, about which nobles fled and which stayed. If you'll have us, we'd like to help."

Lady De studied them for a long moment. These were people who had served Michlen, who had sat in council while foxes were sent to kill her chickens, while strategies were drawn to destroy her kingdom. She had every reason to turn them away.

But they were also people who had tried. Who had stayed and argued and fought for sanity when sanity was unwelcome. Who had finally, when there was nothing left to save, walked toward the light.

"Get them food," she told Silas. "Then bring them to the counting hall. We have a lot of work to do, and I suspect they know things we need to learn."

* * *

The days that followed blurred together in a haze of logistics and decisions and the constant, grinding work of absorbing a kingdom.

Housing was found—some refugees placed with families who volunteered spare rooms, others housed in hastily constructed barracks that would need to become permanent structures. Food distribution was organized, then reorganized, then reorganized again as the numbers kept growing. Work assignments were made based on skills and needs, matching Crestfall's

farmers with Eggerton's agricultural advisors, Crestfall's craftsmen with Eggerton's guilds.

The Moneylender Lord [DEBT] visited twice, reviewing the numbers, asking pointed questions, nodding with the particular satisfaction of a lender who had bet on the right horse. "You're managing this well," he observed during his second visit. "Better than I expected."

"We prepared," Lady De said simply.

"Most kingdoms don't. Most kingdoms see a crisis and panic. You saw a crisis and made spreadsheets."

"Spreadsheets are how you don't panic. They're how you turn chaos into questions you can actually answer."

The Moneylender Lord smiled—that same grandfatherly expression he'd worn when approving the first loan. "My granddaughter still talks about Duchess Wobbles, you know. The chicken with the funny walk."

"Duchess Wobbles was special," Lady De agreed. "We're raising her daughter now. Same waddle. We're hoping it's genetic."

* * *

Three weeks after Crestfall's collapse, a delegation traveled west to assess the abandoned kingdom.

Lady De led the group, accompanied by Silas, Magnus, the Prophet, and a team of assessors whose job was to document everything—every building, every field, every asset and liability left behind. They crossed the border at dawn, retracing Silas's steps in reverse, climbing the gentle hills and descending into lands that had been enemy territory just months before.

What they found was heartbreaking.

The southern fields, poisoned by Michlen's fertilizers, lay fallow and brown, the soil cracked like old skin. The market square was empty, stalls abandoned mid-sale, goods rotting on tables no one had bothered to clear. The castle itself stood silent, its doors hanging open, rooms stripped of anything valuable by whoever had fled last.

But it was the chicken coops that hit Lady De hardest.

"They left them," she said, standing before rows of cages that still held birds—thin, neglected, some clearly sick, all of them the victims of a kingdom that had stopped caring for anything except war. "They just... left them."

"There wasn't time," Silas said quietly. "Or the will. Chickens were assets, not priorities. When everything fell apart, they were abandoned like everything else."

Lady De walked through the coops, counting birds, assessing their condition, already calculating what it would take to save the ones that could be saved. Many would need veterinary care. Some would need to be put down humanely. But others—the healthier ones, the ones who had survived neglect through sheer stubborn vitality—could be rehabilitated.

"We're taking them," she said.

"All of them?" Magnus asked.

"Every one we can save. They didn't choose to be born in a kingdom run by a fool. They're victims of Michlen's choices, just like the people who fled." She reached into a cage and gently lifted a hen—thin, bedraggled, but alert enough to look at her with something that might have been hope. "We count eggs. And we take care of what we count."

The chicken rescue took three days.

Wagons were dispatched from Eggerton, loaded with cages and feed and water for the journey back. Workers moved through the coops with care and patience, handling each bird gently, assessing health,

separating the salvageable from the suffering. Silas kept meticulous records—how many birds, what condition, what care they would need.

By the time they were done, two hundred and thirty-seven chickens had been loaded for transport to Eggerton. Forty-three had been humanely euthanized, too sick or injured to save. The rest—the ones who had died before the rescue arrived—were buried in the fields they had once fed.

"This is the strangest conquest in history," Magnus observed, watching the wagons roll east with their cargo of clucking refugees. "We didn't take their gold or their weapons or their throne. We took their chickens."

"The chickens are worth more," Lady De said. "Gold can be spent. Weapons rust. Thrones are just chairs with better marketing." She watched the wagons disappear over the hill. "But chickens lay eggs. And eggs become more chickens. And more chickens become more eggs. That's not conquest—that's compound interest."

* * *

The assessment took two weeks in total. When it was complete, the Prophet compiled the results into a comprehensive report that told the story of Crestfall's fall in numbers and projections.

The southern fields would need three to five years to recover, with careful soil management and selective planting. The castle could be converted into administrative offices or a school—it was too large and too expensive to maintain as a residence. The market infrastructure was sound and could be revived once there were people to use it.

The total cost of rehabilitation, including debt service on the loans required to finance it, would strain Eggerton's resources for years. But the projected returns—expanded farmland, increased population, new trade routes, economies of scale—made the investment worthwhile.

"We're not just absorbing a failed kingdom," the Prophet concluded at the court meeting where she presented her findings. "We're investing in our own future. The short-term costs are significant. The long-term gains are transformational."

"And the risks?" the King asked.

"Documented and managed. We know where the vulnerabilities are. We have contingencies for each one. This isn't a gamble—it's a calculated expansion based on verified numbers and realistic projections."

"Unlike Michlen," Queen Verity observed.

"Unlike Michlen," the Prophet agreed. "Who expanded based on fantasy and spite. We're expanding based on math and necessity."

The King looked around the table—at his court, his advisors, the ledgerkeepers and prophets and oracles who had guided Eggerton through crisis after crisis. "Then we proceed," he said. "Carefully, deliberately, and with our eyes on the numbers."

"Always," Lady De said. She placed an egg on the table—her constant companion, her reminder. "We proceed the only way we know how. By counting what we have and protecting what we count."

* * *

That night, Lady De walked through Eggerton's expanded chicken coops, checking on the newest arrivals.

The Crestfall chickens were already settling in—fed properly for the first time in weeks, housed in clean coops with fresh bedding, clucking with the particular contentment of birds who had been rescued from neglect. Some of them would never fully recover; the damage was too deep, the deprivation too long. But others were already showing signs of improvement, their feathers regaining luster, their eyes brightening.

She stopped at one cage where a hen sat quietly—one of the thinnest rescues, touch and go for several days, now finally stable enough that the veterinary team had cautiously upgraded her prognosis from "uncertain" to "hopeful."

"You made it," Lady De said softly. "Against all odds, you made it."

The hen blinked at her. Then, with the particular stubbornness of a survivor, she shifted on her nest—revealing, beneath her, a single egg.

Small. Brown. Perfect.

Lady De stared at it for a long moment. A Crestfall chicken, laying an Eggerton egg. The old kingdom, becoming part of the new. The cycle continuing despite everything—despite foxes and poison and a

king who thought destruction was the same as creation.

She reached in carefully and lifted the egg, feeling its warmth against her palm.

"This," she whispered to no one in particular, or perhaps to everyone. "This is what we were counting all along."

* * *

Sidebar Note from Kari: When something falls, you have a choice. You can pick through the rubble for valuables and walk away. Or you can assess, plan, rebuild, and make something better than what was there before. The second choice is harder. It's more expensive. It requires patience and resources and faith that the investment will pay off. But it's the only choice that actually builds anything. Everything else is just scavenging.

Chapter 13

The Eggs We Count

One year later, the counting hall was fuller than it had ever been.

The original Court of Accounts sat in their familiar seats—Queen Verity with her ledgers, Sir Ludo with his quarterly reports, Garrick at his post by the door, Lady Continuance with her long memory and longer view. But now they were joined by others: Silas, no longer a refugee but a full member of the court, his meticulous records now serving a kingdom that actually read them. Lady Ashworth and Lord Pemberton, their knowledge of Crestfall's territory proving invaluable in the rehabilitation efforts. New faces from the absorbed population, learning Eggerton's ways, contributing their own.

And at the center of it all, Lady De, an egg in her palm as always.

But this egg was different. This egg had a story.

"One year ago today," she began, her voice carrying clearly through the crowded room, "we received word that Crestfall had fallen. That a kingdom built on envy

and destruction had finally destroyed itself. And we faced a choice: stand apart and let the pieces scatter, or step forward and build something new from what remained."

She held up the egg—the same one she'd taken from the rescued Crestfall hen that night in the coops. It had been preserved, carefully, a relic of a turning point.

"This egg was laid by a chicken that should have died. She was starved, neglected, abandoned by a kingdom that saw her as an asset to be used up rather than a life to be protected. We rescued her because that's what Eggerton does—we count what we have and we take care of what we count. Even when 'what we have' is a half-dead hen from an enemy kingdom."

She paused, letting the weight of the moment settle.

"She's still laying, by the way. Became one of our best producers once she recovered. Her name is Lady Persistence, and she has seventeen descendants now in our coops."

Light laughter rippled through the room. Lady Persistence had become something of a celebrity—the chicken who symbolized everything Eggerton had done right.

* * *

The Prophet [CASH FLOW FORECAST] rose to deliver her annual report, and the numbers told a story of their own.

"Total egg production: up forty-three percent year over year, driven primarily by the integration of Crestfall's rehabilitated flocks and the new coops built with loan funds. Revenue: up fifty-one percent, reflecting both increased volume and premium pricing for our quality reputation. Expenses: up thirty-eight percent, primarily debt service and integration costs, but trending downward as efficiencies scale."

She turned to a new page of her report.

"Debt position: significant but manageable. We're eighteen months into our expanded loan, payments current, interest coverage ratio healthy at 2.8. The Moneylender Lord has expressed interest in extending additional credit for phase two of the Crestfall rehabilitation—he calls us his 'model borrowers.'"

"What's phase two?" Garrick asked.

"Soil remediation for the southern fields. The Prophet's original projections estimated three to five years for natural recovery. With active intervention—

cover crops, careful fertilization, managed grazing—we can cut that to eighteen months and have those fields producing again by next harvest."

"And the cost?"

"Substantial. But the return is generational. That land, properly managed, could increase our total agricultural output by thirty percent." The Prophet set down her papers. "The numbers work. They're aggressive, but they work."

Silas leaned forward. "They work because we built them on reality, not fantasy. Every projection is backed by verified data. Every assumption has been stress-tested. This isn't Michlen's approach of guessing and hoping—it's counting and knowing."

Lady De nodded. "Then we proceed. Carefully, as always. Eyes on the numbers."

* * *

The Oracles [FINANCIAL RATIOS] delivered their analysis next, their three voices weaving together in their characteristic pattern.

"Current ratio: 2.3," the first Oracle reported. "Comfortably above the 2.0 threshold we maintained before the expansion. Liquidity is strong."

"Quick ratio: 1.6," the second Oracle added. "Even excluding inventory, we can meet short-term obligations without strain."

"Debt-to-equity: 0.7," the third Oracle concluded. "Higher than our historical average of 0.3, but well within healthy parameters for a kingdom in growth phase. More importantly, the trend is improving—down from 0.85 six months ago as revenues catch up to investment."

"What would an outside observer say?" the King asked. It was a question he'd learned to ask, understanding that internal confidence meant nothing if external credibility didn't follow.

The Oracles exchanged glances. The first one answered: "An outside observer would say that Eggerton absorbed a failed kingdom, took on significant debt to do it, and emerged stronger than before. They would say our fundamentals are sound, our management is disciplined, and our growth trajectory is sustainable."

"They would also say," the second Oracle added, "that we did something unusual. We expanded through compassion rather than conquest. We took on debt to save people, not to destroy competitors. And somehow—against every cynical expectation—it worked."

"Because compassion and good business aren't opposites," Lady De said. "They're the same thing, if you're counting correctly. Every refugee we fed became a worker who contributes. Every chicken we rescued became an egg we sell. Every kindness we extended became loyalty that compounds."

She turned the preserved egg over in her hands. "The math always worked. We just had to be willing to do it."

* * *

After the formal reports, the court settled into less structured discussion—the kind of meandering conversation that often produced the best ideas.

"What happens to Crestfall?" Pip the Daily Scribe [THE JOURNAL] asked. He'd been documenting everything, as always, and the question of nomenclature had been nagging at him. "As a name, I mean. Do we keep

calling the western territories 'Crestfall,' or do they become part of Eggerton?"

"They're already part of Eggerton," Magnus Vaultwell [THE GENERAL LEDGER] said. "Administratively, financially, practically. The name is just... legacy."

"Names matter," Lady Continuance [STATEMENT OF EQUITY] observed. "They carry history. The people from those territories—do they want to forget where they came from? Or remember it?"

Lady Ashworth, who had spent more time with the resettled Crestfall population than anyone, considered the question. "Both, I think. They want to remember that they survived something terrible. But they don't want to be defined by it."

"Then perhaps the land keeps the name, but the people don't," Lady De suggested. "The Crestfall territories. Not the Crestfall people. They're Eggerton citizens now—same rights, same responsibilities, same future. But the land remembers what happened there, and we don't pretend it didn't."

"A memorial," Lord Pemberton said slowly. "Not of conquest, but of consequence. What happens when a kingdom ignores its numbers. What happens when a leader destroys instead of builds."

"And what happens when another kingdom chooses differently," Silas added. "The Crestfall territories aren't a trophy. They're a lesson."

The room was quiet for a moment, absorbing the weight of what they'd done and what it meant.

"I'd like to build something," Lady De said finally. "On the border. Where the roads cross between what was Crestfall and what was always Eggerton. A marker of some kind. Not a wall, not a gate. Just... a reminder. That this is where two kingdoms became one. That this is where counting eggs mattered more than chasing chickens."

"What kind of marker?" the King asked.

Lady De smiled. "I was thinking a statue. Of a chicken. Wearing a very small crown."

The laughter that followed was warm and genuine—the sound of people who had earned the right to be ridiculous because they'd done the work to be serious.

* * *

The meeting adjourned in late afternoon, but Lady De lingered in the counting hall after the others had gone.

She stood at the window, looking out at the market square below. It was busier than it had ever been—more stalls, more merchants, more customers, more life. The omelet station had expanded into a permanent restaurant. The monthly egg-coloring contest had become a beloved tradition. The quarterly chicken fashion show drew visitors from kingdoms that had once been strangers.

And everywhere, eggs. Bought and sold, counted and protected, the foundation of everything they'd built.

"You're thinking."

She turned. The King stood in the doorway, watching her with the quiet attention that had always been his gift.

"I'm counting," she corrected. "In my head. All the things that could have gone wrong and didn't. All the choices we made that turned out to be right. All the moments where we could have panicked and didn't."

"That's a lot of counting."

"It's what I do." She held up the preserved egg—Lady Persistence's first Eggerton egg, the symbol of everything. "My father taught me that counting was a form of prayer. That every accurate number was an act of faith in the idea that truth matters. That if you just

keep counting honestly, keep protecting what you count, keep building more than you started with... eventually the math works out."

"Does it?"

Lady De looked at the egg. At the market below. At the kingdom that had absorbed another kingdom and emerged stronger for it.

"So far," she said. "So far, it does."

She slipped the egg back into her pocket—her constant companion, her reminder, her proof that small things could become big things if you just kept counting.

"Same time tomorrow?" the King asked.

"Same time tomorrow. And the day after. And the day after that." She smiled. "That's the secret, you know. There's no final victory. No moment where you've won forever and can stop trying. There's just tomorrow, and the counting that needs to be done, and the eggs that need protecting."

"That sounds exhausting."

"It sounds like life." Lady De moved toward the door, toward the evening that waited, toward the thousand

small tasks that would fill the hours between now and sleep. "And life, done right, is worth the exhaustion."

She paused at the threshold.

"Besides," she added, "the chickens need feeding. And I hear Lady Persistence's great-granddaughter is about to start laying. Another generation. Another chance to count something new."

The King watched her go, this woman who had held a kingdom together with accurate numbers and steady hands and an egg always in her pocket. Then he turned back to the window, to the market below, to the life that Eggerton had built one careful count at a time.

Somewhere, a chicken clucked. Somewhere, an egg was laid. Somewhere, a ledger was updated, a number verified, a truth recorded.

The Court of Accounts continued its work.

And the eggs kept coming, as they always had, as they always would—small, brown, perfect, and worth every bit of the counting.

* * *

Sidebar Note from Kari: This is the real ending, you know. Not a triumphant moment where trumpets play and everything is solved forever. Just another day. Another count. Another choice to keep doing the work that works. The businesses that last aren't the ones that win big once—they're the ones that show up every day and count the eggs. That's not a story with a climax. That's just life. And life, done right, is the best story there is.

Epilogue

The Spyglass

The ship creaked beneath his feet, a sound Michlen had grown accustomed to in the months since he'd fled.

He stood at the stern rail, watching the coastline recede into morning mist—not Crestfall's coast, not anymore, but a distant shore where he'd spent the winter working odd jobs and avoiding anyone who might recognize the former prince of a failed kingdom. The ship was bound for somewhere warmer, somewhere further, somewhere he might finally stop running from what he'd done.

In his hands, he held a spyglass.

It was a simple instrument—brass and leather, nothing ornate—purchased from a dockside merchant with almost the last of his coin. He'd told himself he needed it for practical reasons. Watching for weather. Spotting landmarks. The usual lies a man tells himself when he's really buying something for entirely different purposes.

He raised it to his eye now and trained it on the vanishing shore.

Through the lens, the blurred coastline sharpened into detail. He could see the harbor he'd just left—tiny figures moving along the docks, boats bobbing at anchor, the normal business of a normal port that had no idea a ruined king had passed through it. Beyond the harbor, hills rose green and gentle, dotted with farms that were not his farms, worked by people who were not his people.

He adjusted the focus, sweeping the spyglass slowly across the horizon.

And there, at the very edge of visibility, he saw it: a smudge of land that might have been Crestfall. Or what used to be Crestfall. What was now, according to the sailors' gossip he'd overheard in every port, something called "the Crestfall territories"—part of a larger kingdom, absorbed and rehabilitated, its people fed by someone else's markets and protected by someone else's walls.

Eggerton.

He'd spent months avoiding that name. Months refusing to ask questions about what had happened after he fled, what had become of his kingdom, his

people, his disastrous legacy. But sailors talked, and merchants gossiped, and eventually the story had reached him whether he wanted it or not.

They'd saved it. Not conquered—saved. Taken in his refugees. Rescued his chickens. Rehabilitated his poisoned land. Done everything he should have done and hadn't, everything Silas had tried to tell him and he'd refused to hear.

The spyglass trembled slightly in his hands.

* * *

He thought about Silas often, in the quiet hours when the sea stretched empty to every horizon and there was nothing to do but think.

The ledgerkeeper who had stood in corners and recorded everything. Who had tried, again and again, to show him numbers he didn't want to see. Who had finally—when there was nothing left to save—walked east with his journals and given them to the enemy.

No. Not the enemy. Michlen could admit that now, in the privacy of his own mind, with no one to perform for and nothing left to defend. Eggerton had never been the enemy. They'd just been... there. Thriving.

Happy. Everything his father had envied and everything Michlen had been too proud to learn from.

If he'd listened to Silas—really listened, not just waited for the man to stop talking—what would have happened?

The question haunted him. The spyglass in his hands felt like an accusation.

All those tools he'd had. All those resources. A kingdom, a treasury, advisors who knew their craft. And he'd ignored them all, certain that his instincts were worth more than their expertise, that his vision was worth more than their numbers.

"You can't run a kingdom if you don't believe in the numbers that tell you how it's running."

He didn't know who had said that—it was just something he'd overheard in a tavern, a fragment of the larger Eggerton legend that was spreading through every port and market. But it stuck with him, lodged in his mind like a splinter he couldn't remove.

He'd had numbers. He'd had tools. He'd had everything he needed to succeed.

And he'd pushed it all aside, because the numbers told him things he didn't want to hear.

* * *

The spyglass was the first tool Michlen had used properly in years.

He realized this slowly, standing at the rail as the ship carried him further from everything he'd known. The spyglass did one thing: it helped you see clearly what was far away. You pointed it at something, you adjusted the focus, and you looked. You didn't argue with what it showed you. You didn't insist that the image should be different. You just... saw.

That was what tools were for. Not to confirm what you already believed, but to show you what was actually there.

Silas's ledgers had been a tool. The Oracles' ratios had been a tool. Every report and projection and analysis that Michlen had dismissed—all of them had been tools, designed to help him see clearly what was far away, what was coming, what needed to be done.

And he had refused to look through any of them.

He lowered the spyglass and stared at it—this simple instrument that had cost him almost nothing and taught him almost everything. Brass and leather and glass, arranged in a particular way to serve a particular

purpose. Useless if you didn't raise it to your eye. Useless if you refused to believe what it showed you.

But invaluable if you did.

* * *

The coastline had disappeared entirely now, swallowed by distance and mist. Michlen stood alone at the stern, the spyglass heavy in his hands, the future heavy in his chest.

He was thirty-two years old. He had no kingdom, no crown, no subjects, no legacy worth claiming. He had a handful of coins, a borrowed berth on a merchant ship, and a brass spyglass that had become, somehow, the most important thing he owned.

What did you do with a life after you'd ruined it?

He didn't know. But he was starting to think—just starting, tentatively, the way you test a bridge before trusting it with your weight—that the answer might involve learning to use the tools he'd been given.

Not just spyglasses. Not just ledgers. All of it. The advice of people who knew more than he did. The evidence of outcomes he didn't want to accept. The humility to look at something clearly and admit that

what he saw was real, even if it wasn't what he'd hoped for.

"See, that's the nice thing about math," someone had said—the Lady of Eggerton, according to the stories. "There is only one right answer."

Michlen had spent his whole reign insisting that math was negotiable. That numbers were opinions. That if he just pushed hard enough, believed strongly enough, the world would rearrange itself to match his vision.

It hadn't. It never did. The math was the math, and the math had been right, and he had been wrong.

The spyglass couldn't show him how to fix what he'd broken. Couldn't show him how to become the kind of person who used tools instead of ignoring them. Couldn't show him what waited at the end of this voyage or any voyage after.

But it could show him what was there, if he was willing to look.

That, Michlen decided, was a start.

* * *

The sun rose higher, burning off the mist, and the merchant ship sailed on toward whatever came next.

At the stern, a man who had once been a prince raised a spyglass to his eye and watched the horizon—not for what he wanted to see, but for what was actually there. He stayed there for a long time, looking, learning, beginning the slow work of understanding what he'd refused to understand before.

Behind him, invisible now, a kingdom called Eggerton was waking up to another day of counting eggs. Markets were opening. Chickens were being fed. Ledgers were being updated, numbers verified, truth recorded one careful entry at a time.

Michlen would never see it again. Would never walk those streets or count those eggs or be part of what they were building. That door had closed the night he fled, and some doors, once closed, stayed closed forever.

But somewhere, on a ship sailing toward an uncertain future, a man was finally learning to use his tools.

And somewhere, in a counting hall he would never enter, a woman with an egg in her pocket was preparing for another day of steady work—unaware

that the enemy she'd defeated was, in his own small way, becoming a student of everything she'd tried to teach.

The spyglass caught the light as Michlen lowered it, brass gleaming like a small sun.

He tucked it carefully into his coat, protecting it the way he should have protected so many things, and turned to face the bow of the ship.

Whatever was coming, he would try to see it clearly.

It was the least he could do. It was also, he was beginning to understand, everything.

— THE END —

Now go be brilliant.

Eggerton is a good kingdom. The books are balanced. The chickens are plump. The omelets are legendary. Then the foxes come. And after that, nothing is theoretical anymore.

This is the story of a steward who counts instead of chases, a court that argues with facts, and a kingdom that survives not by shouting louder, but by knowing what's true.

A business parable disguised as a saga— for anyone who's ever sensed that the numbers were trying to tell them something important.